

INBRIEF



TANKER Foundation receives donation of ₹25 lakh from GRT

The TANKER Foundation received a donation of ₹25 lakh from GRT Group as a part of their Corporate Social Responsibility initiative on Tuesday. Chairman of GRT Group G. Rajendran, and managing directors G.R. Ananthapadmanabhan, G.R. Radhakrishnan, and Jayashree Vummidi handed over the donation during a special programme. The company contributed a total of ₹8.5 crore to 15 NGOs working across various sectors. The support to TANKER will significantly enhance access to life-saving transplant and dialysis treatment for underprivileged patients battling kidney disease, a press release said. Latha A. Kumaraswami, managing trustee of TANKER Foundation, thanked the group for their support. Lakshmi Rao, trustee of the foundation, was also present.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (July 9, Thursday), the following articles are available:

- What is the right to be forgotten? newsth.live/righttobeforgotten
- The quantum computing age will only begin when we silence the noise newsth.live/quantumage

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

34 electricity substations to come up in city, three neighbouring districts

This is to improve the distribution network in Chennai, Tiruvallur, Chengalpattu, and Kancheepuram. City's power demand crosses previous peak of 5,000 MW. While overall availability remains adequate, localised outages continue to occur: official

POWER POINT

R. Srikanth
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Power Distribution Corporation Limited (TNPDCL) will soon begin work on setting up electricity substations of varying capacities to improve distribution network in the city and the neighbouring districts of Tiruvallur, Chengalpattu, and Kancheepuram.

With Chennai's power demand having crossed the previous peak of 5,000 mega watt (MW) for the first time this year, the residents have been complaining of power disruptions in various parts of the city.

White Paper

The White Paper, presented by Minister for Energy Resources C.T.R. Nirmalkumar recently, had blamed the power disruptions, particularly in the city, on the failure to commission new substations of 230-kilo volt (KV) as well as the 110- and 33-KV ones to replace the old substations on the



Infrastructure upgrade: A senior TNPDCL official said a total of 13 substations would be established in the North Circle and 21 in the South Circle. FILE PHOTO

distribution side.

A senior official of the TNPDCL said Chennai city, along with its three neighbouring districts, had been witnessing sustained growth in residential, commercial properties, and industries, increasing the power demand to an all-time high of 5,000 MW.

The official added that while the overall power availability remained adequate, localised interrup-

tions continued to arise due to network constraints, overloading of transformers and feeders during evening peak hours, an ageing infrastructure, inadequate source redundancy, and underground cable failures.

The TNPDCL, along with the Tamil Nadu Transmission Corporation (Tantransco), had proposed to establish a total of 34 sub-

New substations have been proposed at Ennore, Kanagavallipuram of Tiruvallur, Perambur Barracks Road, Perumcherry, Thirumazhisai Industrial Estate, Egmore, and Medavakkam. In Medavakkam, a 110/11-KV substation would be set up on the multi-storey apartment site at Pura-vankara, he said.

Residential corridor

The TNPDCL has also set a road map for the burgeoning residential corridor along the GST Road for establishing a 400/230/110-KV substation.

Similarly, substations are proposed to be constructed in Ambattur, Selavoyal, Vanagaram, Nolambur, Thalambur, Irumbuliyur, Manapakkam, Vengal, and Sunnambu Kolathur on the Thorai-pakkam-Pallavaram Radial Road.

T. Ashok, a resident of Perumbakkam, said that with the Metro line coming on the Sholinganallur-Medavakkam stretch, power transmission had to be improved to prevent low voltage and power disruptions.

Nagenthran urges Minister to provide textbooks to schools

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

BJP State president Nainar Nagenthran on Wednesday cited a report published in *The Hindu* that pointed out that even a month after classes began, many government schools across the State were yet to receive their textbooks. He criticised Minister for School Education Rajmohan for the delay.

Referring to the report, Mr. Nagenthran said it had come as a shock to parents. The Minister assumed office just about the time when schools reopened after the summer vacation. He should have ensured that textbooks were available for the students, the BJP leader said.

Mr. Nagenthran further criticised Mr. Rajmohan for supporting his Cabinet colleague S. Keerthana over her recent comments. "The [School] Education Department is given to you. The future of children is dependent on your actions." He further requested the Minister to ensure the quality of education and safety of children in government schools.

Apollo Children's Hospital launches centre of excellence in paediatric urological robotic surgery

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Apollo Children's Hospital, on Wednesday, launched a Centre of Excellence in Paediatric Urological Robotic Surgery, marking the completion of more than 400 paediatric robotic procedures.

Speaking at a press conference on the occasion, V. Sripathi, senior consultant paediatric urologist and robotic surgeon, traced the journey of the robotics programme, from skill mastering and performing increasingly complicated procedures on children and infants, to building awareness and finally,



Dignitaries at the launch of the centre of excellence at Apollo Children's Hospital in Chennai on Wednesday. M. SRINATH

training surgeons, and other healthcare institutions all over the country.

Noting that the outcomes of their procedures were analysed, Dr. Sripathi

said that they had found a 98.4% success rate in an analysis of 200 pyeloplasty procedures performed over a period of 10 years, and the results of this were published.

Overseas collaboration

The aims of the Centre of Excellence included performing advanced urological procedures, adding services for robotic thoracic surgery, gastrointestinal surgery, and hepatobiliary procedures. This apart, overseas collaborations were also being looked into, Dr. Sripathi further said.

Ilankkumaran Kaliamoorthy, chief executive of-

ficer, Apollo Hospitals, Chennai Region, highlighted the significance of robotic procedures for children: minimal blood loss, shorter hospital stays, less pain and very small scars, and quicker recovery periods.

Sindoori Reddy, director - strategy, Apollo Hospitals, formally launched the Centre of Excellence.

The event was attended by a number of parents and their children who had undergone robotic procedures.

Sushila Narayanasamy, unit head, Apollo Women's & Children's Hospitals, Chennai, was among those who participated.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In a week-long Statewide operation focused on proactive and preventive policing measures, the Tamil Nadu Police arrested 949 offenders and executed 2,385 non-bailable arrest warrants.

Acting on the instructions of Director-General of Police and Head of the Police Force Mahesh Kumar Aggarwal, intensive enforcement drives were launched against History Sheet (HS) rowdy elements, habitual offenders, and absconding accused persons involved in various criminal activities.

T.N. Police arrest 949 offenders in a week-long operation held across the State

In the operation that commenced on July 1, continuous checking and surveillance were undertaken against the suspects. A total of 24,025 HS rowdies and others who had come to the adverse notice of the police were checked, of whom 949 offenders were arrested and sent to jail.

During the special drive on Non-Bailable Warrant (NBW) execution, 2,385 NBWs were executed through sustained enforce-

ment efforts. Intensive efforts were also being undertaken to execute pending NBWs and secure absconding accused.

The sustained enforcement measures and special drives had enhanced coordination among field units, strengthened preventive policing, improved execution of warrants, and facilitated focused action against habitual offenders and trouble-mongers, thereby reinforcing law enforcement and contributing to the maintenance of public order and safety of women and children across the State, an official statement issued by the police headquarters said.

Issue of appointment of V-Cs to State-run varsities heats up

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The issue of appointment of Vice-Chancellors to State-run universities is heating up once again. While Higher Education Minister P. Viswanathan said on Tuesday that the government had sent a proposal to the Governor for the expansion of Search Committees for V-Cs, the Madras High Court has ordered notice to the UGC and the State government on a plea seeking urgent intervention over the failure to appoint V-Cs.

The petition made two pleas: either a direction to the University Grants Commission (UGC) to step in and draw up a scheme for the appointment of V-Cs under Section 12 of the UGC Act, 1956, or the appointment of a high-powered panel headed by a retired Chief Justice of a High Court or a Supreme Court judge to oversee the process of appointment of V-Cs.

The Bench of Chief Justice S.A. Dharmadhikari and Justice Arul Murugan posted the case for next hearing on July 29, along

T.N. government has sent a proposal to the Governor for the expansion of Search Committees for V-Cs

with other cases related to V-C appointments.

"The plea is limited to an interim solution for appointment of V-Cs only, pending the decision by the court on the validity of the Acts," said Senior Advocate N.L. Rajah, counsel for the petitioner, P. Bhaskar.

"Fifteen universities are headless, five more are going to be, soon. This is sure to have affected the students, the standard of education, and the finance flow of these universities," Mr. Rajah said.

The Tamil Nadu situation was quite similar to that of West Bengal, where a stand-off between the Governor and the State government over V-C appointments had led the Supreme Court to appoint a Search-cum-Selection Committee, headed by former Chief Justice of India U.U. Lalit, in 2024 to oversee the process, the

petition submitted.

Meanwhile, the Higher Education Minister's statement on expansion of Search Committees has raised hopes of a truce between the Lok Bhavan and Fort St. George. In October 2024, the then Governor, R.N. Ravi, had directed the State government to notify a search committee with four members, including a UGC Chairperson's nominee, for the appointment of a V-C to the Tamil Nadu Physical Education and Sports University. The State government objected to this stand, setting off a chain of events and court cases leading to the present stalemate.

In the past couple of weeks, at least two review meetings of the Higher Education Department were chaired by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, where issues pertaining to the stalemate over V-C appointments were discussed as priority. It is reliably learnt that the proposal for expansion of Search Committees was sent to the Law Department for clarification. The ball, now, is in the Governor's court.

A total of 139 entries receive awards in The Hindu Margazhi Competition 2025

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The results of *The Hindu* Margazhi Competition 2025 are out and the list of winners in both Hindustani and Carnatic styles is now available on its website.

A total of 139 prizes, including 43 first prizes, 43 second prizes, and 27 third prizes, have been awarded by the panel of judges. There are also special mention certificates for children who did well and earned appreciation from the vidwans and vidushis who marked their performances.

A total of 1,063 video entries were received from Carnatic and Hindustani music enthusiasts for *The Hindu* Margazhi Music Contest that ended mid-January 2026.

The entries were sorted and sent to the judges in March 2026, who watched the presentations to check if the raga, krithi, and thala were perfect and took tough decisions to finalise the marks.

Violin vidushis and composers LN Sisters - M. Lalitha and M. Nandini -



who judged entries in the instrumental category, said: "Over the years, we have been seeing more and more dedicated students participating in this competition. We are able to see that they are also very knowledgeable. This is a very unique platform for students of music for this category to showcase their talent and hard work and get recognition from *The Hindu*. We wish the participants all the very best to keep the tradition alive and take it forward."

Vocalist Varalakshmi Anandkumar, senior disciple of late vidwan D.K.

Jayaraman, said: "It has been a privilege to judge the Margazhi competitions of *The Hindu* for the past several years and I have never ceased to be amazed by the wealth of talent exhibited by the contestants. In fact, judging these competitions is both an aural delight and an agonising dilemma, as each singer demonstrates their talent in different dimensions. To choose the best among these formidable line-ups often calls for multiple listening sessions. It is amazing to listen to a girl or boy, barely out of the teens, sing a Dhanyasi or Thodi with the kind of understanding that one could gain only with years of singing and listening. In the same way, it is amazing that brilliant singers emerge from areas that are seldom heard of, in Kerala, Andhra, Karnataka, and even in the U.S. Hats off to *The Hindu* for promoting solid musical values through the Margazhi Music Competitions."

Hindustani guru and vocalist Lalita Sharma, who trained under Pandit Jasraj, said: "I am very happy to see more number of sin-

gers and instrumentalists participating in this competition every year. I see that over one-third of the participants are good and have a sound base in music. It is very promising to see such youngsters, who are singing with so much awareness."

Two new judges

The panel of judges this time had two new faces - mridangam vidwan Sridharan Sankaran, who started learning mridangam from Thiruvavur S. Janakiraman in the Palani Subramanya Pillai lineage and received advanced training from Mannargudi Easwaran, and Carnatic vocalist Sajeev Chandramana, who started learning music at the age of four and underwent advanced training under Varkala C.S. Jayaraman.

Both musicians said that they had enjoyed watching the entries and giving marks. They were also fascinated by how young children had patiently learnt to perform and sent in their entries.

For the full list of winners, click on newsth.live/winnerlist.

CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The Music Academy Madras
Mid Year Dance Festival 2026
Today: At the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall: From 6.00 p.m. to 7.15 p.m. - Bharatanatyam recital by P Sundaresan - From 7.30 p.m. to 8.45 p.m. - Kuchipudi recital by Pranamyia Suri - Programme under the endowment by the family of late Shri M N Subramaniam

Kedaram (R) 9884066767
Today 9.7.26 6.15 p.m. @ Raghasudha Hall Ch-4 Rithvik Rajia - Vocal, SaiRakshith - Violin, N.C. Bharadwaj -Mridangam, Dr. S. Karthick - Ghatam. All are welcome.

Narada Gana Sabha Trust, Ph: 24993201
Today Main Hall (Sathguru Gnanananda Hall)- 6.30 pm - Vaggeyakara Bharatham - Musician - Baby Sreeram. Dancer - Roja Kannan and Disciples (Endowment by Nrithyopasana) All are welcome.

Pushpanjali Cultural Trust
Today 5.30 p.m. at R.K Swamy auditorium Mylapore Bharathanatyam by students of Tamil Isai Kalloori Guru Dr. Himaja Athulkumar 7 p.m. Bharathanatyam by Ms. SREE VIHANIKA (Dis.of Smt Kala Srinivasan)

The Mylapore Fine Arts Club(Regd.)
Phone 24997755/42607755
22nd Year Drama Festival Today 6.45 P.M. Theatre Marina presents ANNIAL by Prasanna & R.Giridharan. All are Welcome

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INBRIEF



Greater Chennai Police hold drug awareness programme

The Greater Chennai Police, in association with Easwari Engineering College, organised a ‘Drug Free Tamil Nadu-2026’ awareness programme at the college in Ramapuram on Wednesday. Greater Chennai Police Commissioner A. Amalraj participated in the event and urged students to stay away from drugs and adopt healthy habits during their college years. He highlighted the physical, mental, and social consequences of substance abuse. As part of the programme, students took the “I am Against Drugs” pledge. The Commissioner also launched the “I am Against Drugs” signature and selfie awareness campaign to reinforce the anti-drug message.

Man found hacked to death inside math in Vyasarpadi

A 20-year-old man was found hacked to death inside a math at Samiyar Thottam in Vyasarpadi in the early hours of Wednesday. The police launched an investigation to ascertain the motive and identify those involved. The deceased was identified as Naresh, 20. According to the Vyasarpadi police, he was found lying in a pool of blood with severe injuries and his face mutilated. The murder is suspected to have taken place around 3 a.m. The police are analysing CCTV camera footage from the area to trace the assailants.

Man with brain lymphoma recovers after cell therapy

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 49-year-old patient who was diagnosed with a rare life-threatening form of brain lymphoma was successfully treated using advanced and indigenous cell therapy at a private hospital in Chennai.

V. Arun Ramanan, Clinical Lead and Senior Consultant (Medical Oncology), Gleneagles Hospital Chennai, on Wednesday, said that before a few months, the patient Karan Madhusudhanan was admitted to the hospital with complaints of persistent headache, giddiness, difficulties in walking and using his left arm. He was diagnosed with a life-threatening brain cancer called primary central nervous system lymphoma.

Treatment involved collecting the patient's immune cells and infusing these back into the body as CAR-T cells

The patient, despite being given chemotherapy and other first-line treatments, could not neutralise the lymphoma. The hospital proposed to treat him with NexCAR19 (talitagtene autoleucel), an indigenous CAR-T cell therapy. This involved collecting the patient's immune cells through a specialised procedure called leukapheresis and infusing these back into the body as CAR-T cells. The procedure helped the cells to modify, recognise, and attack the cancer cells.

CITY MATTERS

R. Aishwaryaa
CHENNAI

The Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority (CMDA) is mulling cancellation of certain infrastructure projects, including the Global Sports City plan, beachfront development, and waterfront restoration plans, as it grapples with outstanding liabilities of roughly ₹3,500 crore.

The liabilities are mainly due to the construction work, land acquisition amounting to ₹1,500 crore, and the *Vada Chennai Valarchi Thittam*, which constitutes ₹1,000 crore.

This proposal to cancel the projects will take shape only after the State government takes a call, according to a source.

“Whichever project has not yet been taken up, CMDA is in the process of cancelling it. Once the proposal [for cancellation] is approved [by the State], the CMDA will formally announce the cancellations,” the source said.

The Global Sports City project, for which former Chief Minister M.K. Stalin had laid the foundation stone in February 2026, will be handed over to the Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu, the source added.

It was planned across a 127-acre site near Sathyabama Institute of Science and Technology at an estimated cost of ₹261 crore. This project took shape in November 2024, after the then Deputy Chief Minister and Sports Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin held a meeting with officials of various departments, including Tamil Nadu Sports Development Authority, Water Resources Department, Tamil Nadu Housing Board, and CMDA.

Among other projects proposed to be dropped are beach-front development works, covering the stretches from Marina to Besant Nagar, Elliot's Beach to Neelankarai, Neelankarai to Akkarai, Akkarai to Kanathur and Kanathur to Kovalam, including Marina Beach, Broken Bridge, Elliot's Beach, Thiruvanmiyur,



Facing uncertainty: A concept image of the Global Sports City, one of the projects the CMDA plans to shelve.

Neelankarai, Akkarai, Uthandi, Muttukadu, and Kovalam.

Marina corridor

Notably, in April 2025, the CMDA unveiled the ₹18.45-crore Marina Heritage Corridor Development Project, as part of this, spanning 2.5-km from Lighthouse to Island Grounds, with plans for heritage-style bus stops, viewing decks, cycle tracks, police booths and improved pedestrian infrastructure, to enhance

the Marina promenade, while preserving its historic character.

In 2024, the CMDA prepared detailed project reports for the rejuvenation of 10 lakes across the Chennai Metropolitan Area with an estimated ₹100-crore State allocation. The proposed works include lake-front promenades, walking tracks, viewing decks, ecological restoration, wetland restoration, bird-watching areas, and recreational facilities at Velachery, Retteri, Mudi-

chur, Puzhal, Adambakkam, Sembakkam, Perumbakkam, Kolathur, Madambakkam, and Ayanambakkam lakes, according to the CMDA.

“The CMDA does not have funds to go ahead with these projects. The authority is not the custodian [of the waterbodies]. The waterbodies belong either to the WRD or the respective local body,” the source said.

The operation and maintenance of completed projects, including the M.S. Swaminathan Wetland Eco Park at Porur and the air-conditioned bus stand at Retteri Junction, Kolathur, will be handed over to the Greater Chennai Corporation, and that is the model to be followed for the other finished or nearly finished works by CMDA, the source added.

“CMDA took up a lot of works without realising the financial burden. CMDA has outstanding liabilities of around ₹3,500 crore and cannot take up new works in the present financial position,” the source said.

Further, the Authority is

exploring alternative funding options, including external borrowings for future projects. “Typically, planning authorities in cities such as Mumbai and Hyderabad receive government support. CMDA will also require similar support,” the source said. Local bodies have other revenue generation modules such as ticketing few projects, municipal bonds etc., but that is not the same for CMDA, the source added.

Land pooling projects

The proposed land pooling schemes at Thirumazhisai and Madambakkam have also been delayed. According to the source, the Madambakkam scheme is pending owing to litigation challenging the Land Pooling Act, while the Thirumazhisai project is facing financial constraints.

Under the model, 60% of the developed land is returned to landowners, while CMDA retains 40% for roads, parks, open space reservation, water supply infrastructure, and commercial development, the source added.

There is a need to build a national front against BJP: VCK chief

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) founder and Chidambaram MP Thol. Thirumavalavan has been facing severe criticism on social media for his comments that his party is yet to formalise an alliance with the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam and that it would continue to have a friendly relationship with the DMK, which many have observed as “contradictory and confusing”.

On Wednesday, Mr. Thirumavalavan said that he was expressing his point of view from the perspective of the national politics and the need to form a national anti-BJP front.

The barrage of comments over his views resulted in the party publishing a clarification on its official page on X.

The clarification from the party said, “Mr. Thirumavalavan was referring to past events and past positions. However, as usual, certain media outlets have deliberately twisted his remarks and portrayed them as though they represent his current position.”

“Just because DMK inducted an office-bearer of the VCK into their party, I didn't oppose them. There is a necessity to build a national anti-BJP front – both the TVK and DMK should be a part of it. This is my point of view...but many would say that I am confusing everyone. We will see if DMK can be a part of the INDIA bloc,” Mr. Thirumavalavan said.

Vijay inspects hospital for women and children in city

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, on Wednesday, paid a surprise visit to the Institute of Obstetrics and Gynaecology (IOG) and Government Hospital for Women and Children at Egmore in the city.

At the century-old institute, Mr. Vijay visited the ward and the intensive care unit and enquired about the health of mothers undergoing treatment. He also sought feedback from them on the treatment being provided and the facilities available there. Mr. Vijay held a few newborns in his arms.

Accompanied by Minister for Health, Medical Education and Family Welfare K.G. Arunraj and



Warmth and care: Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay holds a newborn at the Institute of Obstetrics and Gynaecology and Government Hospital for Women and Children at Egmore on Wednesday.

Health Secretary Darez Ahamed, the Chief Minister enquired about the medical services being provided at the hospital.

Speaking to reporters later, Dr. Arunraj said the Chief Minister had directed officials to chalk out a plan to develop the hospital into an integrated facility with all amenities. He acknow-

ledged that complaints had been received about staff demanding bribes to show newborns to their families after delivery and said strict instructions had been issued to dismiss those found guilty of such acts. The public can lodge complaints through the 104 round-the-clock health helpline, he said.

☀️🌧️🌡️ Timings
CHENNAI

THURSDAY, JUL. 09

☀️ RISE 05:49 SET 18:40

🌧️ RISE 00:30 SET 13:28

FRIDAY, JUL. 10

☀️ RISE 05:49 SET 18:40

🌧️ RISE 01:18 SET 14:29

SATURDAY, JUL. 11

☀️ RISE 05:50 SET 18:40

🌧️ RISE 02:11 SET 15:35

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	36	25
Chennai Airport	39	30
Chennai City	39	30

Chennai Airport Today
39°C The weather will be mostly dry. Day will be hot and uneasy. Night also will be uneasy.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
38°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be slightly hot and uneasy. Night also will be uneasy. Mostly dry weather to prevail.

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THE HINDU

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Teachers' association demands relaxation of TET qualifying marks

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Graduate Teachers Federation (TNGTF) has urged the School Education Department to relax qualification marks by another 5% in the special Teacher Eligibility Test (TET) exam.

Special marks

In a petition to the department, the federation said, “Special marks should be given in the examination according to the teachers' work experience and higher educational qualifications.”

In September 2025, the Supreme Court ruled that all teachers, except those with less than five years of service, must clear TET to continue in their jobs, with no exceptions even for pro-

motions. In May 2026, the apex court had extended the timeline for acquiring TET qualification by a year.

Change in pattern

Pointing out that over 60% of the questions were asked from Classes IX, X, XI, and XII syllabi in the recently held exam, the federation said that it had caused distress to the teachers. “In the future, the question paper design should be changed so that more questions are asked from the subject related to teachers,” said P. Patrick Raymond, general secretary, TNGTF.

They also urged the government to follow Kerala's model, where teachers who have completed NET, SET, and M. Phil, have been exempted from the qualifying examination.

FMG wing raises concern over examination results as only 12.78% of candidates clear it

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Medical Students Association - Foreign Medical Graduates (TNMSA FMG) wing has expressed serious concern over the outcome of the Foreign Medical Graduate Examination (FMGE) June 2026, in which only 12.78% of the candidates who appeared were declared successful.

In a statement issued, the wing's State secretary S. Vasanth Philip Abishak said the exam was, by all accounts of the candidates, an exceptionally difficult and mentally exhausting one. According to students who appeared for the test, Paper 1 was relatively balanced and manageable.

However, Paper 2 was significantly more challenging, with a large num-



Tough ask: The wing's State secretary said that the examination was, by all accounts of the candidates, an exceptionally difficult and mentally exhausting one. REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

ber of clinical scenario-based questions, image-based questions, and video-based questions introduced for the first time. This had a major impact on time management during the examination.

The National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences (NBEMS) results,

published on July 7, reflect the severity of this difficulty, he said. Out of 37,428 registered candidates, 36,280 appeared for the examination. Of these, only 4,635 candidates passed, while 31,645 did not qualify. This relates to a pass percentage of only 12.78%, meaning that only one in

eight candidates who appeared for the examination managed to clear it.

One of the concerns is that a large number of candidates fell just short of the qualifying mark. The pass mark for FMGE is 150. As per the available statistics, 327 candidates scored exactly 149, missing qualification by one mark. A total of 1,022 candidates scored between 147 and 149, while 4,157 candidates scored between 140 and 149. In addition, 9,905 candidates scored between 130 and 149, he said.

When compared to previous sessions, the decline in performance is even more alarming. The FMGE pass percentage stood at 18.6% in June 2025 and 23.9% in December 2025, the association said.

In light of these developments, the TNMSA FMG

wing placed certain demands to NBEMS and the National Medical Commission. It called for a comprehensive review of FMGE June 2026. NBEMS must conduct a transparent and detailed review of the exam, particularly examining whether the length of questions, clinical complexity, image/video-based format, and the time allotted were appropriate to fairly assess the actual medical knowledge and competence of candidates. It also called for reframing of the examination pattern.

Prior notice must be issued before introducing new examination formats, the association said. It also urged the bodies to consider reduction of the passing mark for FMGE June 2026 as a one-time exception, Dr. Abishak said.

Tamil Nadu

From Page One

Tiruvallur gas leak: officials seal unit after removal of ammonia

All the supporting departments worked in tandem, she added.

The sealing was done by a team of officials led by Revenue Division Officer S. Ravichandran, who said that the gate of the unit would be locked on Thursday, after the compound was cleared of waste.

While eight workers were still undergoing treatment in hospitals, the district administration had sent 170 workers, who were not affected by the leak back to their homes in Odisha, Assam, and Jharkhand.

“As per the government’s instructions, we booked tickets and sent them along with officials from their respective districts. The salaries of the workers up to June 18 have also been sent to their bank accounts. The workers have been connected with manpower agencies in case they want to return to work in the district,” Mr. Ravichandran added.

620 tonnes of seafood seized

Meanwhile, Central Food Safety officials seized and moved around 620 tonnes of frozen cuttle fish, prawns, squid, and tuna to two private cold storage units last week.

They also lifted samples of the seafood. Around 80 tonnes of the seafood that were contaminated were moved to a private methane plant, where they were ground and converted to sustainable energy.

T.N. moves top court over BC status of converts to Islam

State challenges HC order declaring unconstitutional a G.O. that a convert to Islam from the BCs, MBCs, Denotified Communities or SCs should be treated as BC (Muslim) for reservation benefit

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Tamil Nadu government has appealed against a Madras High Court verdict that a convert to Islam cannot claim the status of Backward Class (BC) Muslim.

The High Court had declared unconstitutional a 2024 Government Order allowing converts to claim BC status.

The court was hearing the petition filed in 2022 by a man from Thoothukudi district, who had embraced Islam and changed his name. He was born to Hindu parents. The certificate issued by the Sunnath Jamath, Kayathar, in 2015 had stated that the petitioner had embraced Islam.

He had applied for a community certificate certifying him as ‘Muslim Leb-



The special leave petition was filed by the Secretary to the State of Tamil Nadu in the Supreme Court.

bai’, a faith he claimed to follow. However, the Kayathar Tahsildar rejected his application. Challenging it, he had moved the court.

Meanwhile, the 2024 G.O. notified that a convert to Islam from the Backward Classes, Most Backward Classes, Denotified Communities or Scheduled Castes ought to be treated as BC (Muslim) for obtaining the benefit of reservation. The High Court, however, held that a Hindu, on conversion to Islam, did not carry forward the benefits of the Hindu caste or sub-caste. The convert’s status in Islam was not decided by the caste he was part of prior to the conversion, it said.

The court pointed out that Christian missionaries and Islamic preachers had maintained that their religions offered social equality, unlike Hinduism, which had a caste hierarchy.

“Having taken such a stand for effecting conversions, it is disingenuous to claim that there is hierarchy in Islam also. In our respectful view, categorising certain sects as Backward and the remaining as Forward is antithetical to Quranic injunctions. Islam seeks to establish an egalitarian society. Everyone is equal in the eye of God. There is no social hierarchy,” the court had said.

The special leave petition was filed by the Secretary to the State of Tamil Nadu in the Supreme Court.

The appeal has arraigned the petitioner in the High Court, Sameer Ahamed N., the Collector, the Revenue Divisional Officer, and the Tahsildar as respondents, who had already filed caveats before the top court.

Panel seeks more time for consultations on anti-honour killing law

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Commission led by retired High Court judge K.N. Basha, which had been tasked by the State government with recommending legislation to prevent caste-based crimes committed in the name of honour, has sought more time to complete its consultations, Minister for Social Justice Vanni Arasu said on Wednesday.

Speaking to reporters at the Secretariat after participating in a review meeting of the Social Justice Department, chaired by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, the Minister said, “The Justice Basha Commission is still receiving petitions and representations from victims through social activists. It has also sought the views of political parties. So far, the VCK and the CPI(M) have submitted representations to the Commission. We have apprised the Chief Minister in this regard. As the consultative process is still going on, Justice Basha has sought more time,” he said.

The Social Justice Department had sought an additional budgetary allocation from the Chief Minister. The allocation for the department would see a substantial increase in this year’s Budget, he said, adding that the State government was taking measures to provide house-site *pattas* to every eligible SC/ST family, and that the Chief Minister would make an announcement in this regard soon.

Further, the Minister said Social Justice Hostels across the State would be upgraded with state-of-the-art facilities, including modern libraries. He said the number of seats under the Chief Minister’s Overseas Scholarship Scheme for studying abroad would be increased, as the Chief Minister had given his approval for the move.

State government to take legal action over deemed university status for three private medical colleges

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

With three private medical colleges obtaining ‘deemed to be university’ status, Tamil Nadu will lose 461 medical seats from the State quota, Health Minister K.G. Arunraj said on Wednesday. He added that the State government was exploring legal action, and would file a writ petition soon.

Two days ago, the State government came to know from the website of the National Medical Commission that Dhanalakshmi Srinivasan Institute of Medical Sciences and Hospital, Srinivasan Medical College and Hospital, and St. Peter’s Medical College had been granted deemed university status, he said.

As a result, the State will



Health Minister K.G. Arunraj at the inauguration of the NalamAI WhatsApp chatbot service. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

lose 461 seats from its pool, Dr. Arunraj said, adding: “These institutions will no longer be required to follow the reservation policy, 7.5% horizontal reservation for government school students, or adhere to the fee structure prescribed by the State government. Instead, they could fill MBBS

and BDS seats independently.” Additionally, 35 seats under the 7.5% quota would be lost, he said.

The State government will also take up the issue with the Centre to make a no-objection certificate (NOC) from the State government mandatory for private medical colleges to obtain deemed university status, he said.

“Dhanalakshmi Srinivasan Medical College and Srinivasan Medical College are owned by DMK MLA Kathiravan. As they fall under the Tamil Nadu Private University category, they did not apply for NOC with the Tamil Nadu Dr. MGR Medical University, and applied directly to the University Grants Commission,” he told reporters after inaugurating facilities at Rajiv Gandhi Government

General Hospital.

The deemed university status had been granted to St. Peter’s Medical College, Hosur, subject to an appeal filed by the Government of Tamil Nadu, he said. Karpaga Vinayaga Medical College had also applied for the status, he added.

Explaining the process, the Minister said private institutions seeking deemed university status must first obtain an NOC from their affiliated university. The affiliated university is required to issue the NOC within 60 days, failing which it shall be deemed to have been granted as per UGC rules.

In June 2023, the Karpaga Vinayaga institution, which has an engineering college and a medical college, had applied to Anna University and Tamil Nadu

Dr. MGR Medical University for an NOC. However, no action was taken for 60 days. The NOC was issued in September 2023 during the previous regime, and the same was revoked two months later. The institution approached the High Court, and in April 2025, the court ruled that as the NOC was not issued within 60 days, it was deemed to have been issued as per UGC rules. No appeal was filed against the order by the previous government, he said.

The Minister also launched NalamAI, a WhatsApp chatbot service. The service, available on 96192 22999, has been introduced in 22 districts, where the public can generate the outpatient slips without having to wait in queues.

T.N. govt. asks State Election Commissioner to step down

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay-led government has asked State Election Commissioner B. Jothi Nirmalasamy, a retired IAS officer, to step down from her post.

Sources confirmed the development to *The Hindu*. The State Election Commission is a constitutional and autonomous body responsible for conducting free and fair elections to local self-governments.

Ms. Nirmalasamy, also the Chairperson of the Tamil Nadu Delimitation Commission, assumed office as the State Election Commissioner in March 2024 for a five-year term. Her tenure ends in May 2029.

The tenure of the rural local bodies in 28 districts ended on January 25, 2025, while that of the local bodies in nine other districts will end on October 19 this year. The tenure of urban local bodies in the State will end on March 1, 2027. The State Election Commission is taking steps to conduct elections to the local bodies after the completion of the ward delimitation exercise.

As the Chairperson of the Tamil Nadu Delimitation Commission, she has been overseeing the sanctioning and mapping of wards. She also oversaw the indirect byelections to several urban local bodies following the resignation of the Mayors of a few Corporations.

The development comes on the heels of the

chairpersons and members of various statutory bodies and other agencies, who were appointed during the previous DMK regime, stepping down from their posts.

What the rules say

However, according to Article 243K of the Constitution, the State Election Commissioner is appointed by the Governor, and shall not be removed from office except in the like manner and on the like grounds as a Judge of a High Court. Further, the conditions of service shall not be varied to the State Election Commissioner’s disadvantage after appointment, subject to the provisions of any law made by the State legislature.

Ms. Nirmalasamy is yet to decide on the matter.

HC grants anticipatory bail to Senthilbalaji, his brother in TVK MLA bribery case

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI



V. Senthilbalaji

The Madras High Court on Wednesday granted anticipatory bail to former DMK Minister V. Senthilbalaji and his brother R.V. Ashok Kumar in a case related to TVK MLA N. Elaiyaraja having reportedly been offered a bribe of ₹35 crore.

Justice G.K. Ilanthirayan granted the relief on the condition that both petitioners must appear before the investigating officer twice a day until further orders, and cooperate with the probe. The orders were passed after hearing senior counsel N.R. Elango and P. Kumaresan, appearing for the petitioners, and Government Counsel (criminal side) R. John Sathyan, appearing for the prosecution.

In his submissions, Mr. Elango alleged that the case had been filed with a political motive, and that the averments in the complaint regarding an attempt to topple the government were the perceptions of the TVK MLA, and nothing more. He said Assembly Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar was elected unanimously,

and there was no reason to bring any resolution against him as mentioned in the complaint.

It was also brought to the notice of the court that no monetary transaction had taken place, and that the complaint only mentions an offer of ₹35 crore having been made. Mr. Elango concluded his arguments by stating that the petitioners were willing to cooperate with the investigation and be available for questioning as and when the police summons them.

On the other hand, Mr. Sathyan told the court that it was a serious case of an attempt having been made “to destabilise the government”. He said the investigation was at a nascent stage, but the probe conducted so far by the Gre-

Both of them must appear before the investigating officer twice a day until further orders

ter Chennai police had revealed that the complainant was only one among the 10 TVK MLAs whom the accused had sought to “poach”.

He said some of the accused had stayed in a hotel at Guindy in Chennai to execute the crime, and their presence had been confirmed through network tower locations. He said the investigation had led the police team to Bengaluru, where some “startling revelations” had been made, and much more was to be unearthed. “It seems Hawala money is involved in this case,” the Government Counsel said.

Opposing the grant of bail to the petitioners, he said the investigating team was collecting materials regarding other MLAs who had been lured, and said the middlemen appeared to have been offered a brokerage of ₹5 crore for executing the deal.

Commercial Taxes Dept. to launch virtual hearings for taxpayers

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Commercial Taxes Department will introduce virtual personal hearings for taxpayers at its 15 appellate offices from Thursday. It has also introduced a computer-based random allocation system for GST refund applications to improve transparency and speed up processing.

Minister for Commercial Taxes and Registration D. Logesh Tamilselvan on Wednesday chaired a review meeting with officials of the Commercial Taxes Department on Goods and Services Tax (GST) and non-GST collections, and the functioning of the intelligence, audit, and legal wings.

There are 338 assessment circles in the Commercial Taxes Department across the State, with 12.4 lakh registered traders under the GST Act. If any discrepancies are found in the GST returns filed by taxpayers, notices are issued to them after scrutiny, followed by a personal hearing notice.

Under the current system, taxpayers are required to appear in person

before the jurisdictional assessing officer to provide an explanation. Notices and personal hearings have been issued in 58,000 cases so far. To simplify the process and safeguard the interests of traders, guidelines have been issued for conducting personal hearings virtually to ensure transparency and fairness, an official release said.

The virtual hearing facility will particularly benefit traders who are unable to appear in person, including those located in remote areas, by enabling them to participate in proceedings within the stipulated time. The virtual hearing system will be implemented in 15 appellate offices from July 9, the release said.

To ensure transparency and eliminate bottlenecks, guidelines have been issued to disburse GST refunds promptly. During the previous financial year, the department disbursed around ₹5,000 crore in refunds, the majority of which related to unutilised Input Tax Credit on exports. Such refund applications will now be allocated through a computer-based system to streamline the refund process, it added.

All private schools in T.N. must display fee structure on notice boards, websites: Madras HC

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI



The court said the Director of Private Schools should ensure that the schools update their fee structure periodically.

The Madras High Court on Wednesday invoked its extraordinary jurisdiction under Article 226 (power to issue writs) of the Constitution and ordered that all private schools in Tamil Nadu must display their fee structure on their notice boards and websites.

Justice M. Dhandapani ordered that the Director of Private Schools must ensure that the fee structure, fixed for individual schools by the government-appointed fee determination committee, is updated by the private schools periodically on their notice boards and websites.

The judge made it clear that all schools that fall under the Tamil Nadu Private Schools (Regulation) Act, 2019, must follow the directions and display not only the fees fixed by the committee, but also other fees approved by the competent authority.

The directions were issued while disposing of a writ petition filed by All India Private Educational Institutions Association, represented by its general

secretary K. Palaniappan of Chennai, which had challenged a circular issued by the Director of Private Schools on June 1, 2026.

The circular mandating the display of the fee structure on school notice boards had been issued by the Director on the basis of an order passed by the Tamil Nadu State Information Commission (TNSIC) on May 25, 2026, while disposing of a plea under the Right to Information Act.

Assailing the TNSIC’s order and the circular on various grounds, the association had contended that such directions had been issued without analysing

whether the RTI Act would apply to private unaided educational institutions, and whether those institutions would fall under the definition of the term ‘public authority’.

The judge agreed with the association that private educational institutions, which were neither substantially financed nor controlled by the State/Centre, would not fall under the ambit of ‘public authority’ and therefore, the direction issued by the TNSIC would not stand the test of legal scrutiny.

Nevertheless, pointing out that private schools fall within the regulatory mechanism of the law passed by the State legislature to govern them, the judge held that the schools were bound to make their fee structure public, and that the High Court could issue such a direction by exercising its extraordinary jurisdiction.

Parents looking for a good choice of school for their children must be able to know about the fee collected by individual schools so that they could make an informed choice, Justice Dhandapani added.

INBRIEF



Six missing A.P. fishermen
feared dead; search called off

The six fishermen who went missing after their boat capsized off Visakhapatnam on Saturday are feared dead. The multi-agency search launched to trace them was called off on Wednesday. State Fisheries Minister Kollu Ravindra said that despite a four-day search, no trace of the crew or boat wreckage could be found. The Andhra Pradesh government has announced an ex gratia of ₹10 lakh each for the families (in photo) of the fishermen, says a PTI report.

Two arrested for raping
woman in Secunderabad

Two persons have been taken into custody for allegedly raping a 40-year-old woman in Secunderabad on Tuesday. The woman had come to Hyderabad to attend a reality show, but could not locate the organisers' office. One of the accused approached her and offered to take her to the office. He then took her to a building in Secunderabad and raped her. Another man who arrived later also allegedly raped her. They fled after the woman raised an alarm, the police said.

Student dies in Bengaluru
school, family blames teacher

A 12-year-old Class six student collapsed and died at a private residential school in north Bengaluru on Wednesday. The boy was studying at the Sterling English Residential School in Kadayarappanahalli. His uncle alleged the boy was beaten by a physical education teacher and made to jog three rounds on the ground. "In the last round, he collapsed and died. They are saying it was a cardiac arrest. The school staff are hiding something," he added.

Hyderabad cybercrime police arrest
36 from five States, recover ₹49 lakh

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Thirty-six persons across five States were arrested by the cybercrimes wing of the Hyderabad police in connection with 14 cases during special operations carried out in June. A total of ₹48.98 lakh was recovered and refunded to victims.

According to the police,

the arrests followed multiple investigations launched after complaints were received through the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (NCRP). The operations led to the registration of 52 FIRs in June.

Of the 36 accused, 22 were involved in investment fraud cases, five in social media-related offences, six in matrimonial fraud and three in job

fraud. Twenty-six accused were apprehended from Telangana, four from Maharashtra, and two each from Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Delhi.

Phones seized

The police also seized eight mobile phones, six debit cards, three SIM cards, two chequebooks and a bank passbook used in the offences.

Officials said the ₹48.98 lakh refunded to victims pertained to 24 cyber fraud cases.

Trading fraud accounted for the highest number of cases, with eight complaints involving losses of ₹70.70 lakh, of which ₹10.56 lakh was recovered. Six OTP fraud cases saw complete recovery of the entire ₹15.88 lakh lost by victims.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

Mr. J.V.S. SATHISH (50), Father of Mr. Advait, Chennai- 600033, expired on 07.07.2026, Eyes donated to Rotary Rajan Eye Bank (Project of Rotary Club of Madras T.Nagar), Chennai- 17 (Ph: 28340500).

Mr. ANANDA NIRMAL, G (35), Son of Mr. Ganesan, Chennai- 600014, expired on 06.07.2026, Eyes donated to Rotary Rajan Eye Bank (Project of Rotary Club of Madras T.Nagar), Chennai- 17 (Ph: 28340500).

Dinesh N K
03/06/1948 - 06/07/2026
With profound grief we inform that our beloved father passed away on 6th July 2026.
He will be deeply missed and lovingly remembered by all whose lives he touched.
Fondly remembered by:
His loving family, Kishan, Ambika, Anya and Lakshmi

OBITUARY
Dr. K. PANCHALAN
Age 77
Registrar - IIT, Madras (Retd.)
Funeral Details
Besant Nagar Cremation
9th July 2026
3.00 PM to 4.00 PM
— Deeply Mourned by —
Family & Friends
+91 98411 87872

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

3rd Year Remembrance
SHRI A.P.KUNHIKANNAN
09.12.1927 - 09.07.2023
VISIONARY & FOUNDER OF MALAYALA KALAGRAMAM, New Mahe, Kerala
You might not be with us, but you live with us always, In our thoughts and forever in our hearts.
Your legacy of Love, Principles and Vision continue to guide us and inspire us in every sphere of Life.
Lovingly remembered by
Brothers, Sister and all Family Members of Akkul Poil House.

BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE

CELEBRATING VISION, CELEBRATING LEGACY FOUNDER'S DAY
On this day, we honour the visionary who laid the foundation of excellence. Join us as we remember the founder's dream that built generation of leaders.
ALADI ARUNA GROUP OF INSTITUTIONS
Einstein College of Engineering
Einstein College of Arts & Science
Einstein College of Nursing
Aladi Aruna Medical Hospital
Sir.C.V.Raman Nagar, Seethaparanallur, Tirunelveli - 627012. Phone: 0462-2487111

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Karnataka poll officer
denies 'mass SIR' charge

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) V. Anbu Kumar on Wednesday rejected allegations by the Bharatiya Janata Party and the Janata Dal (Secular) that the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the State was being conducted through "mass SIR" exercises. He asserted that the exercise

was being carried out transparently and strictly in accordance with the Election Commission (EC) guidelines and the law.

Addressing a press conference on the progress of the revision, Mr. Kumar said all District Election Officers (DEOs) had been instructed to ensure that booth-level officers (BLOs) visited every household and handed over enumeration forms directly.

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

The search for five people missing after a debris slip at the under-construction Wayanad tunnel road project site at Kalladi, near Meppadi, continued for the second day on Wednesday, with no breakthrough till late in the evening.

The debris slip on Tuesday claimed three lives and left 10 injured.

Heavy rain and inclement weather hampered the rescue efforts, slowing the removal of debris and posing challenges to rescuers.

Speaking to reporters after a review meeting at Kalpetta, Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said the government's priority was to trace the missing people.

"The search in Zone I and Zone II has been completed, but the missing people could not be located. The search operation has now been extended to Zone III and will continue through the night. It is expected to be completed by Thursday morning. If required, a search will also be carried out in the river on Thursday morning," he said.

Three discharged

The Chief Minister said that of the 10 injured, three had been admitted to the intensive care unit of a private hospital, with two in a serious condition. Four others are being treated



A search team at the site of the debris slip at the under-construction tunnel project near Meppadi in Wayanad district. PTI

Will conduct detailed
probe, says Satheesan

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Kerala Cabinet on Wednesday decided to conduct a detailed investigation into the reasons that led to the debris slip at the construction area of the Meppadi-Kallady tunnel in Wayanad.

Chief Minister V.D.

Satheesan said, "The Union government had accorded environmental clearance after stipulating around 50 conditions regarding the construction activities. The probe will look into whether the company implementing the project has followed these. The work on the project will be restarted only after this."

ed at a hospital, while the remaining three have been discharged.

He announced an ex gratia of ₹5 lakh to the families of those killed in the tragedy. The government will bear the treatment cost of the injured.

Stating that the debris

Force (NDRF) with support from the police, Fire and Rescue Services personnel, and volunteers, continued with the aid of heavy earthmoving machinery to clear the massive mound of debris. Cadaver dogs were also deployed to help locate those believed to be trapped under the debris.

Mr. Satheesan said the bodies of the three persons who died in the debris slip would be taken to their native places.

Officials said the body of Anmol, a native of Jharkhand, was flown to Ranchi on an IndiGo flight. They said the remaining bodies would also be transported to their native places, subject to the availability of flights.

Centre offers help

Union Home Minister Amit Shah spoke to Mr. Satheesan on Wednesday and extended all support from the Centre for the rescue and rehabilitation efforts.

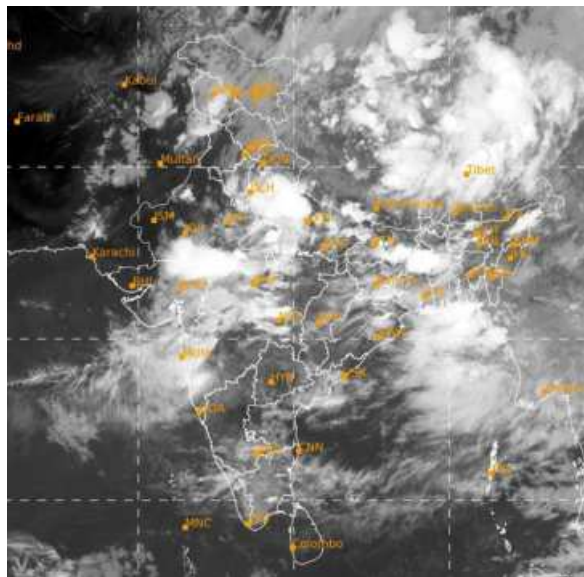
A statement issued by the office of the Chief Minister said Mr. Shah held a telephonic conversation with the Chief Minister.

Meanwhile, in view of the India Meteorological Department issuing a red alert for extremely heavy rainfall in Wayanad, Collector D.R. Meghashree has declared a holiday for all educational institutions in the district on Thursday.

However, the holiday will not apply to residential schools and residential colleges.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



Forecast for Thursday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Gujarat, Rajasthan, Himachal Pradesh, Delhi, Uttarakhand, Bihar, Assam, Meghalaya, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura, Sikkim, West Bengal, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Konkarn & Goa, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Karaikal, Kerala and Mahe

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	88.1	29.1	26.0	Kurnool	36.5	27.4	
Ahmedabad	20.9	33.5	27.1	Lucknow	33.6	27.4	
Aizawl	40	26.0	19.0	Madurai	38.5	26.5	
Bengaluru	28.1	21.3		Mangaluru	30.3	23.7	
Bhopal	34.6	30.4	24.2	Mumbai	125	29.3	24.0
Bhubaneswar	34.0	27.2		Mysuru	28.6	20.2	
Chandigarh	0.4	32.0	25.6	New Delhi	14.2	30.8	25.4
Chennai	39.2	29.6		Patna	35.6	27.9	
Coimbatore	28.8	22.5		Port Blair	31.0	26.4	
Dehradun	9.2	28.8	24.2	Prayagraj	1.9	34.4	27.0
Gangtok	22.6	21.2	18.4	Puducherry	38.2	28.6	
Goa	11	32.0	25.5	Pune	94.4	24.2	21.7
Guwahati	7.4	33.6	26.6	Raipur	32.0	25.8	
Hubballi	27.0	22.0		Ranchi	29.1	23.0	
Hyderabad	4.5	33.1	25.0	Shillong	11	23.0	17.5
Imphal	28.3	25.3		Shimla	24.1	21.0	
Jaipur	0.4	33.1	26.4	Srinagar	33.2	19.6	
Kochi	17	29.8	23.2	Thiruvananthapuram	0.7	33.0	24.5
Kohima	24.0	20.0		Tiruchirappalli	38.3	29.0	
Kolkata	0.4	33.1	27.9	Vijayawada	37.6	27.0	
Kozhikode	24.6	28.2	24.9	Visakhapatnam	32.0	27.7	

CITY	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad	27	34	56	106	110	104	In observation made at 4.00 pm, Arrah, Bihar
Bengaluru	11	30	63	—	104	104	recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 253 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Naharlagun, Arunachal Pradesh recorded a healthy AQI score of 14
Chennai	6	14	31	50	82	104	
Delhi	15	37	46	77	92	104	
Hyderabad	11	17	31	43	56	104	
Kolkata	16	24	17	86	102	104	
Lucknow	9	21	51	36	44	104	
Mumbai	9	81	12	40	85	104	
Pune	7	42	47	26	32	104	
Visakhapatnam	16	52	10	49	130	104	

Air Quality Code: 1 Poor 2 Moderate 3 Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.
PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Karnataka
plans body to
check creches

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Following the recent case of alleged abuse of children at a daycare centre on the premises of IT major Caggemini, the Karnataka government is planning to appoint a nodal agency to monitor such facilities.

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

E-TENDER
CPM /GSU/ NWR/Jodhpur on behalf of The President of India invites E - Tenders for the following work up to 15.00 Hrs. on the mentioned date.
Tender No.: SNT-GSU-JU-2026-27-02R
Name of work : S&T work in Connection with -"Proposed New Block Station along with development of Goods Shed at Manklav Station."
Approximate cost of work : Rs. 4,71,25,807.08
Bid Security : Rs. 9,42,500.00
Date & Time of opening E-Tender : 31.07.2026 at 15.00 Hrs.
Date & Time of closing E-Tender : 31.07.2026 at 15.30 Hrs.
The details of above E-tender are available on website www.ireps.gov.in 974-D/26
Follow us on: www.facebook.com/NWRRailways www.instagram.com/NWRRailways www.youtube.com/NWRRailways

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE (Survey & Construction)
For and on behalf of the President of India, Chief Administrative Officer (Construction), North Western Railway, Head Quarter building, Jawahar Circle, Jaipur invites online Open E-tendering System (Two Packet) for the following work on prescribed electronic forms :-
Tender No.: NWR-SC-HQ-JP-01-2026-2027
Name of the Work: "Rate contract for carrying out Final Location Survey (geotechnical studies, preparation of drawings) and other preliminary activities for preparation of DPR and EPC tender documents in connection with anticipated survey work for new lines, bypass lines, gauge conversion, doubling, etc. of all four divisions of North Western Railway".
Mode of Tender : Open (Two Packet System)
Estimated Project Cost : ₹ 322677346.74 (Thirty two crore twenty six lakh seventy seven thousand three hundred forty six rupees and seventy four paise only.)
Bid Security : ₹ 6453600.00 (Sixty four lakh fifty three thousand six hundred only.)
Completion Period : 36 (Thirty Six) Months
Tender Closing Date and Time : 29.07.2026 15.00 Hrs.,
Website particulars where complete details of E-tender can be seen : www.ireps.gov.in
Note: No manual tender/s will be accepted. 976-D/26
Follow us on: www.facebook.com/NWRRailways www.instagram.com/NWRRailways www.youtube.com/NWRRailways

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

Open Tender through E-Tendering 2026-27
NIT No: LWS-TC-OPN-EC1600HP-2026R
Date-07.07.2026
Name of work : Work of Engine major schedule overhauling/repair of 1600 HP DEMU DPC, Model QSK50L, Make-CIL, Quantity- 06 Nos. at Loco Workshop, N.W. Railway, Ajmer for 01 year
Estimated Cost of work : Rs. 15,21,75,461/-
Address of the NIT issuing office : Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer (Loco) Diesel Loco & Wagon Workshop Lal Patak, Ajmer (Raj.)-305001
Earnest money to be deposited : Rs. 3043500/- (Only through net banking or payment gateway on IREPS portal)
Last Date and time for submission and opening of E-Tender : 28.07.2026 up to 15.00 E-Tender will be opened at 15.30 on same day. Due to indispensable reasons bid opening schedule may change.
Website particular where complete details of e-tender can be seen and participated : www.ireps.gov.in
(Note- This is E-tender so tenderer can participate through e-tendering process only on mentioned website within bidding period) For and on behalf of The President of India, Dy. CME/Loco Ajmer invites e-tender with following details, interested firms/tenderer may participate through IREPS portal in this e-tender. 975-D/26
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SOUTHERN RAILWAY

E Tender Notice No. J-SG-OT-16-2026-662346, Dated:07-07-2026.
The Senior Divisional Signal & Telecommunication Engineer, Southern Railway, Palghat - 678002 invites Open Tender through 'online' tenders for the following works.

Name of work:	Augmentation of Block Working Arrangements by Provision of Solid State Block Instruments in lieu of Existing FM Block instruments in POY-CNV and VNB-NIL Single Line Block Sections of Palakkad Division, along with Associated EI Alterations and Other Signalling Works at POY and CNV Stations
App Cost of work	₹ 1,44,69,883.92
Bid Security	₹ 2,89,400
Cost of tender document	₹.0
Validity of offer	60 days
Completion period	12 months
Date & Time of opening	After 15.00 hrs of 24.07.2026

Detailed Tender notice alongwith Terms & Conditions can be viewed over the web site <http://www.ireps.gov.in>
Sr. Divisional Signal & Telecommunication Engineer, S.Railway, Palghat-678002. (For and on behalf of President of India)



Checkbox caste

An open-ended method of counting caste may not yield usable data

The rehearsal for the second phase of Census 2027, underway in 16 States and Union Territories since July 6, carries a key feature: an “open column” where respondents can state their caste, which the enumerator will record. Unlike the 2011 Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC), which also had this feature, this counting of caste in the Census itself has statutory backing. The pre-test ends on July 20, and the government says that it will then finalise the methodology for counting caste. The hope is that the pre-test findings will corroborate what is known: an open-ended response on caste yields only unwieldy data, as seen in the 2011 SECC, which eventually proved unusable. It is not difficult to understand why. The method led the 2011 SECC to return more than 46 lakh “caste names”, against the 4,147 in the 1931 Census, the last to tabulate caste. Respondents entered surnames, sub-castes and clan names as if interchangeable, inflating the count into incoherence. The Centre told the Supreme Court in 2021 that the SECC figures were too error-ridden to be relied upon for reservation. The pre-test should instead point to a better method – using the digital Census’s hand-held devices, pre-loaded with a curated list of castes and sub-castes, so that the enumerator selects the ‘correct’ entry after asking the respondent. Mistakes and mismatches will happen, but as the 2022-23 Bihar caste survey revealed, this method could return more usable data.

Unlike the other identities – linguistic, religious and gender – that the Census notes, caste is an abstract, irrational one that designates people not by biological, physical, or professed attributes, but by a perceived, primordial identity conferred at birth and arranged in a hierarchy. Even this hierarchy is not self-evident, with the perceptions of social status of different castes often contradicting one another. India’s Constitution, committed to social justice, set itself against caste by abolishing untouchability, forbidding caste-based discrimination and holding out the promise of a republic where birth would not determine a citizen’s standing. So why count caste when the very act of enumeration can ossify or reify this abstract identity? The only rationale is that self-perceived or imposed caste identity creates social inequities, and welfare and social justice measures that address caste-based injustice can, over time, be expected to delegitimise the casteism rather than entrench it. Through sharper targeting of welfare and affirmative action, empirical caste data can also inform questions of the creamy layer and the sub-categorisation of castes and classes already benefiting from reservation. In these, better data are indispensable. If caste is to be counted, it should be counted well. The open-ended way of registering it will not serve the intended purpose.

Prisoners of violence

Sri Lanka must do more to uphold order, prevent prison crowding

The killing of 28 people in sudden, apparently uncontrolled violence in an overcrowded prison outside Colombo, on Monday, speaks to a culture of mismanagement and official apathy. Reports of tensions inside the premises emerged on Sunday, with two inmates reported dead initially. Authorities deployed the military around the prison soon after, but the violence escalated on Monday, leaving more than two dozen dead and over 100 injured. Monday’s riots followed a group of inmates tipping off officials on an alleged drug operation on the prison premises. Some inmates reportedly grabbed arms from the guards, while others assaulted rival gang members with clubs and stones, even as guards struggled to contain the violence; eight guards were among those dead. Authorities have transferred hundreds of remaining inmates to other prisons. The incident, one of the deadliest prison riots in Sri Lanka, foregrounds two key challenges facing the Anura Kumara Disسانayake administration – the narcotics menace that it has resolved to wipe out, and the chronic overcrowding in prisons, a concern that rights defenders have repeatedly highlighted for years.

In 2020, the Human Rights Commission of Sri Lanka found prison conditions to be dire, owing to overcrowding and under-resourcing. As of December 31, 2024, the country’s prisons housed 28,278 inmates against an approved capacity of 10,395, operating at nearly thrice their capacity, according to the 2024 Auditor General’s Report. Authorities have linked the immediate trigger for the riots to the drug underworld, which the Disسانayake administration has been trying to crack down on. Justice Minister Harshana Nanayakkara has rightly noted that regardless of the attackers’ motivations or the crimes they are accused of, the death of people in state custody is “deeply shocking”, and that the government accepts responsibility. The Cabinet has appointed a three-member committee headed by a retired Supreme Court judge to carry out a thorough investigation. The government’s response and seeming willingness to probe the causes for the deadly incident, are welcome and necessary. It is the third after the 2012 Welikada prison riots, where 27 inmates were shot dead by police, and the 2020 riots in Mahara, near Colombo, which claimed 11 lives. The pace of the probe and the government’s response will reveal its intent to address long-pending concerns around the country’s prisons. It must work towards improving prison conditions, living standards, and security, to prevent further clashes. Meanwhile, authorities must persist with the efforts to disable drug networks that pose a grave threat to society, including within prisons.

The gloves are off and the ceasefire is in trouble as the United States and Iran traded strikes, once again, on July 8, over the safe passage of commercial ships across the Strait of Hormuz.

However, looking beyond this flareup, the recent visuals coming out of Iran are extraordinary. After more than 40 days of sustained attacks by the combined military power of the U.S. and Israel, the country is projecting an image of pride, defiance, and resilience. The funeral of its slain Supreme Leader, Ali Khamenei, drew millions of mourners and high-level representatives from Russia, China, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Türkiye, Egypt, Iraq, Pakistan, Armenia, and several other countries. Even the Taliban government in Afghanistan was represented. Notably absent were the entire Western bloc, much of Africa, and some regional countries such as the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, and Kuwait, which bore the brunt of Iran’s retaliation during the war.

Did the scenes witnessed reflect the image of a nation defeated? Did the millions of people on the streets, eager to catch a final glimpse of their assassinated leader, appear coerced or forced to mourn? Did the visuals coming out of Tehran and other parts of Iran reflect a nation that is economically bankrupt? The answer to all these questions is a bold ‘no’. What was on display was a nation eager to use this opportunity to tell the world that it is still standing on its own – and may be more powerful, confident and resilient than ever before.

The regime has not only survived the war but has emerged stronger than before, with the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) in full control. Its nuclear programme still remains off the table and there is no mention of its ballistic missile programme in the 14-point Memorandum of Understanding with the U.S. The windfall gains from removal of sanctions, sale of crude oil and natural gas, a defreezing of its money and assets and the monetisation of the Strait of Hormuz promise an economic revival for Iran, although some of it may now be under question after the rapidly escalating situation. This resurrection of Iran almost feels like a revolution, and is a reminder of how a new nation, the ‘Islamic Republic of Iran’ emerged from the Iranian Revolution of 1979, overcoming the threats and challenges from a monarchy supported and abetted by the West.

The first revolution

The 1979 revolution was the culmination of a year-long protests against the Iranian regime, ignited by multiple factors, mainly political repression and economic hardships. There was also a strong undercurrent to reclaim Iran’s cultural and religious legacy which had been



Rajeev Agarwal

Senior Research Consultant at the CRF, Delhi, and the author of the book, ‘Between Tehran and Tel Aviv – Gaza’s Story of Unending War’

A resurgent Iran signals a dramatic shift in West Asian geopolitics

suppressed by the pro-western Shah regime. The combined effect created an unprecedented popular movement led by Ayatollah Khomeini, the exiled cleric and former philosophy professor from Qom, who had been banished in 1964 for opposing the Shah’s reform programme. The movement ultimately overthrew Shah Mohammad Reza Pahlavi.

The Shah and his family fled Iran in January 1979 and Ayatollah Khomeini returned on February 1 to a jubilant welcome. 10 days later, Iran’s armed forces declared their neutrality, effectively ending the Shah’s rule. On April 1, following a successful referendum, Khomeini proclaimed Iran as the Islamic Republic. The new republic drew its legitimacy from three pillars: restoring Iran’s national pride, establishing theological discourse and Islamic governance, and promising economic progress and social justice. However, the 1979 hostage crisis, the eight-year Iran-Iraq war, prolonged nuclear programme-related sanctions, and support for regional militia proxies severely tested the country’s economic and political resilience.

Revolution 2.0

Why is the current post-war situation akin to a second revolution? Like in 1979, this war too has led to the emergence of a stronger and a nationalist regime. However, unlike 1979, when an earlier regime had to be overthrown, this time, the regime, despite being hit badly and its Supreme Leader assassinated, has emerged stronger as it has survived. Once again, key issues such as national pride, dignity, strength and unity are being made the central pillars. And the millions of people on the street now mirror the visuals of millions on the streets of Iran in February 1979 when they welcomed Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini after his return from exile. And, like in 1979, this revolution too promises to bring in long-lasting changes in Iran and the region.

The most prominent change is obviously the security architecture. Soon after the 1979 revolution, the nations in the Gulf had formed the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) in 1981, to forge a common platform to fight the threat from a revolutionary Iran. The region turned to the U.S. which then carried out its most extensive and permanent military deployment after the Second World War – it stationed thousands of troops and hundreds of military assets across multiple bases, promising a security umbrella against Iran (and Iraq).

Well, this war has shattered this myth with the punishment and huge losses that American bases and the countries in the region had to suffer from Iranian strikes. Countries in the region are not only frustrated with the failed U.S. security assurances but are looking at alternatives to

The Indian diaspora as Australia’s identity, its future

The Indian diaspora is now officially Australia’s largest overseas-born community, overtaking the England-born population for the first time. This is not a small demographic footnote. Australia’s population has, for two centuries, been anchored by a British-derived majority. An Indian-origin community now outnumbering it marks a genuine inflection point in how the country understands itself. It is against this backdrop that Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s visit to Australia – his third visit Down Under – will be a trip in which the diaspora is expected to command the spotlight.

The Australia-India relationship has come a long way, from being defined by the simplistic ‘three Cs’ – Cricket, Curry and Commonwealth – to a more meaningful ‘four Ds’: Democracy, Defence, Diaspora and *Dosti*. This shift reflects a decade of institution-building, including India’s participation alongside Australia, the United States and Japan in the Quad, the informal security grouping that has become the backbone of the Indo-Pacific strategy of India and Australia. Mr. Modi’s visit will touch on all four pillars, but it is the diaspora event – a large public gathering billed as ‘Melbourne Meets Modi’ – that is drawing the most attention, precisely because of what this community has come to represent for both nations.

A new migration era

The settlement trajectory of the Australian-Indian community is very different from its counterparts in the U.S. or the United Kingdom. The first significant wave of Indian professional migration to Australia dates only to the 1960s and 1970s,



Teesta Prakash

Research Fellow at the Australia India Institute, University of Melbourne



Hiya Harinandini

Research Fellow at the Australia India Institute, University of Melbourne

The diaspora must be valued not merely as a symbol of partnership, but as a community whose voices matter

climbing after the dismantling of the White Australia Policy – an explicitly racist immigration regime that excluded all but European migrants.

By diaspora standards, this makes the Australian-Indian community still young. A large share of recent arrivals left India during the ‘New India’ years since 2014, a period of rapid outward migration driven by a mix of economic ambition and, for some, disillusionment with the state of democratic institutions at home. Whatever the reasons for leaving, this cohort tends to be more recently and more tightly bound to India – through family, business, remittances and a resurgent nationalist identity. That is what makes Australia’s Indian community distinct beyond just numbers.

The rise of political backlash

As the anti-immigration wave rises across the globe, in Australia this wave has found a specific target in the Indian community. Nationalist street rallies under banners such as ‘March for Australia’ have gathered pace over the past year, and the right-wing populist One Nation party is emerging as the main opponent to the left-of-centre Labor party currently in power. Mr. Modi’s high-visibility diaspora event lands squarely within this tense landscape. By showcasing the scale, accomplishments and mobilisation of the Indian community, it will reiterate the statement – increasingly co-opted by conservative movements – that this community has grown too large, too fast, and too visible.

For Australia, the Indian diaspora is an economic asset and a force multiplier for the country’s multicultural fabric. But a fracturing domestic political landscape means that this asset

secure themselves in the future, including maybe, making peace with Iran.

The second issue is the regime’s survival which had been at its weakest in the past few years due to economic sanctions and growing frustration within over its enforcement of Islamic laws, especially against women. The most recent protests in December 2025, ignited over severe inflation and job losses and massive devaluation of its national currency Rial (1.54 million Rials traded for one U.S. dollar) posed one of the most severe threats to the regime, one which the U.S. too attempted to support and ignite. However, it failed as it was suppressed by a brutal crackdown by the regime. Even the slain Supreme Leader’s advanced age and declining health had raised questions about the regime’s ability to retain control after his death. However, those doubts have now been consigned to history, with the regime emerging stronger and more firmly in control.

The third important factor is identity. If the first revolution gave the nation a ‘Religion First’ ideological identity, this war has brought national pride to the fore and made it the primary agent of resilience and defiance. Iran’s ability to absorb the punishment of military strikes, endure the pain and then strike back effectively, have brought people and nation together.

The fourth factor has to relate to the economy. A nation which has survived and sustained under severe economic sanctions for almost three decades, now faces a pleasant possibility of huge influx of money into its coffers thanks to a possible easing of sanctions, defreezing of assets and sale of petroleum products. The monetisation of the Strait of Hormuz is obviously a bonus and now a powerful negotiating instrument with Iran.

A balancing act for India

India clearly has a decision to make. The war marked India’s definite and noticeable tilt toward the Israel-U.S.-United Arab Emirates bloc, with several decisions that many analysts have found difficult to explain or defend. By sending a Minister-led delegation to the funeral, India may have walked a diplomatic tightrope. Going forward, however, it will have to make a strategic choice on how to balance its ties with Iran and the wider Gulf region, which itself appears deeply divided after the war.

Iran is resurgent and is unlikely to let go of the opportunity that this war has provided it. The scale of the irreversible changes unfolding in Iran and the region may become clearer over time. However, one thing is certain – the security and economic landscape of the region has changed forever. How Iran uses this opportunity, and how the region responds, will shape the destiny of its people and the region for decades to come.

can just as easily be recast as a liability in public discourse. Mr. Modi’s visit should be a reminder to policymakers that failing to invest in better understanding this growing and dynamic community carries real stakes for the future of this strategic partnership.

Beyond numbers and narratives

For India, the diaspora has long been framed as a source of pride and a connecting tissue of cultural links to Australia as a strategic partner. But pride and sentiment are not the same as understanding. What is missing – on both sides of the relationship – is a serious, evidence-based picture of how this diaspora actually lives, trusts and participates in Australian civic life, beyond the headline statistics on income, education and trade that has long been the mainstay of government discourse. If both countries are serious about treating the diaspora as a genuine pillar of their partnership rather than a talking point, that requires concerted efforts to capture their experiences of settlement which are far from monolithic.

Australia’s demographic transformation is not a passing trend. It will permanently reshape its national identity from an antipodean one to one that is far more entangled with India and the wider Indo-Pacific. That means sustained research, stronger engagement with civil society, and policies that build social cohesion rather than taking it for granted. If democracy, defence, diaspora and *dosti* are to remain the four pillars of the partnership, then the diaspora must be treated not merely as a symbol of the relationship, but as a constituency whose experiences and trust deserve to be understood.

stage. Amid the excitement, a talking point is the controversial round of 16 clash between Argentina and Egypt. Disputed decisions have reignited allegations of Argentina being favoured – an issue that gained prominence during the 2022 World Cup in Qatar. One hopes that the rest of the tournament will be free from controversies

C.K. Subramaniam,
Navi Mumbai

The timeless parable of David and Goliath unfolded once again on football’s grandest stage as Argentina

confronted an indomitable Egypt. For much of the contest, Egypt dictated not merely the tempo but also the psychology of the game. As the clock drifted towards an Egyptian masterpiece, Lionel Messi compressed an eternity into a fleeting moment of genius, reminding the world that legends possess the rare gift of rescuing history when it appears ready to choose another author.

Vijay Singh Adhikari,
Nainital, Uttarakhand

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

From Page One

Trump declares end to truce, talks to continue

At the core of the escalation lies the question of who controls the Strait of Hormuz.

The MoU calls for the safe passage of tankers through the strait. Iran has opened a route along its coast and asked vessels to use a “designated route” along its coast in coordination with local authorities. Over the weekend, three ships passing through an alternative route along the Omani coast – Marshall Islands-flagged *M/T Al Rekayyar*, Saudi Arabia-flagged *M/T Wedyan*, and Liberian-flagged *M/T Cyprus Prosperity* – were attacked.

Following attack on the three tankers, the U.S. revoked a sanctions waiver it had issued after the MoU was signed that had allowed the sale of Iranian oil. The air strikes followed.

In retaliation, Iran’s IRGC said it had struck “85 U.S. military targets in Bahrain and Kuwait with missiles and drones”. Port Salman, the U.S. Fifth Fleet’s area in Bahrain, and Ali Al-Salem Air Base in Kuwait were among the sites targeted, according to an IRGC statement. The Guards also claimed to have downed an American MQ-9 drone over the southern province of Bushehr.

India expresses concern

India on Wednesday voiced deep concern over the fresh targeting of commercial shipping in the Strait of Hormuz and called upon all parties to exercise restraint. “We urge the parties to return to dialogue and diplomacy to achieve a peaceful and lasting solution to the conflict,” the Ministry of External Affairs said in a statement.

(With PTI inputs)

Russian oil share in India’s imports rises

India’s total oil imports stood at 21.82 million tonnes in May 2026, the highest since January and about 12% higher than what it imported in April. This was, however, about 2.6% lower than what it imported in May last year.

Despite this, the higher oil prices meant that India’s oil import bill still rose significantly in May 2026 – by 23.5% compared to April, and by a sizable 66% over May of last year. This is because the price of oil that India imported stood at \$106 per barrel in May 2026 as compared to \$64 a barrel in May 2025, according to data from the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas.

This price effect is visible in India’s oil imports from Russia as well. While the value of oil imports from Russia grew 83% in May 2026 over its level in May last year, the actual volume of oil imported from Russia fell by 2% over this period.

That said, the share of Russian oil in India’s total oil imports stood at 40.5% in terms of volume and 42.6% in terms of value in May 2026.

A simple calculation based on the volume and value of oil imports from Russia shows that the total price paid by Indian importers stood at \$916 per tonne of Russian oil in May 2026, as compared to the average price of \$870 per tonne that India paid for all its oil imports. This works out to a premium of about \$46 per tonne.

The Commerce Ministry data also shows that India has been sourcing some of its oil from countries that were previously restricted from selling their oil. Notably, the data shows that India imported \$430.5 million worth of oil from Iran in April 2026, which fell to \$277 million in May.

Bishnoi, Brar ordered killing of Nijjar: U.S. DoJ

The Royal Canadian Mounted Police is conducting a parallel investigation into South Asian organised crime, the DoJ said. The U.S. indictment identified Nijjar as “H.S.N.” and the DoJ referred to him as a “prominent Indian political and religious figure”. India had designated Nijjar a terrorist in 2020. DoJ said the killing was carried out by gunmen outside a gurdwara.

The Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) has declared a \$50,000 reward on Brar’s arrest and extradition. Bishnoi, currently at Sabarmati jail in Ahmedabad, and others have been charged for racketeering, targeted killings, shootings, extortion, trafficking of narcotics across international borders, and other crimes around the world whose impact is especially felt in the Indian diaspora. The DoJ said 24 defendants, connected to the three India-based transnational organised crime groups charged with a litany of criminal acts, have been arrested in the U.S., Canada, and Spain. Law enforcement is looking for 10 fugitives – seven in the U.S., two in India, and one in Europe, they said. As part of this investigation, law enforcement has seized approximately 1,000 kilograms of cocaine and one kilogram of heroin along with \$40,000 in cash and a dozen firearms.

Key accused in rape of minor in Bengal killed

The mother of the accused refused to claim the body. “I don’t have any disappointment over what happened today. He got the punishment for what he did. He also didn’t understand the pain of a girl. What happened with him is absolutely right,” Sandhya Mondal, mother of Prabhas Mondal, said.

Mamata targets BJP over violence at Trinamool rally

41 injured as Trinamool supporters clash with BJP workers during protest, says party statement; former CM claims police failed to prevent attacks; rally was held to protest Baruiপুর rape-murder

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Violence erupted at a Trinamool Congress procession in Kolkata on Wednesday, as Trinamool supporters clashed with BJP workers. Denouncing the chaos, party chief and former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee said that lawlessness has prevailed in the State since the Bharatiya Janata Party came to power two months ago.

In all, 41 Trinamool workers and supporters were injured and were admitted to the SSKM Hospital after they were subjected to physical assault and brutality unleashed by BJP goons, according to a Trinamool statement on Wednesday evening.

“They are keeping a watch on us. But when a girl is raped, there the police are not available... Both men and women have been manhandled and physically abused by goons



Police officials at the site after a clash broke out between BJP and Trinamool workers at a protest rally in Kolkata on Wednesday. PTI

they [the BJP] have hired. Is this the ‘paribartan’ (change) that the people of Bengal had desired?” Ms. Banerjee asked, addressing a protest outside her house.

The Trinamool rally was organised to protest the brutal rape and murder of a 12-year-old girl in Baruiপুর, which has led to high tensions across the State. The procession was set to move from Hazra Crossing

to Ballygunge Phari, but clashes between Trinamool and BJP workers broke out in the Hazra area and continued in pockets across the rally in multiple places.

Ms. Banerjee had not joined the rally in person because the number of participants was capped by the High Court. When violence broke out, however, she came out of her home to address protes-

ters. She alleged that party workers are not being allowed to go anywhere and have practically been put “under house arrest”. She also alleged that their hand-held microphones had been taken away despite the High Court’s permission to use them.

‘Lawlessness in Bengal’ “The ones who steal from the donations of Ram used slogans in the name of Ram in our rallies trying to disrupt our protests,” Ms. Banerjee added. She blamed the police for “allowing” the disruptions to Trinamool rallies and failing to take action against miscreants who attacked the party workers, claiming that lawlessness in Bengal is now worse than in Uttar Pradesh.

BJP State president Samik Bhattacharya responded by saying it is a free and democratic State, adding that Ms. Banerjee could walk in as many rallies as she wanted.

LeT militant killed in anti-terror operation in Kashmir’s Shopian

The Hindu Bureau
SRINAGAR

Security forces on Wednesday spotted the body of a Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) terrorist at an encounter site in south Kashmir’s Shopian, where an anti-militancy operation was on for the past five days.

‘Eliminated in firefight’ “One LeT terrorist, identified as Zakir Ganai, has been eliminated in the firefight. Arms, ammunition and other war-like stores were recovered. The operation is in progress,” said an Army spokesman.

The Army said a joint operation was launched based on specific intelligence input from the Jammu and Kashmir Police in

A joint operation was launched based on intelligence input from the J&K Police, the Army says

Shopian’s Chanapora area. “During the search operation, an exchange of fire took place between the security forces and the terrorist,” the Army said.

Meanwhile, the Jammu and Kashmir Police, in a post on X, said: “You can run but you can’t hide!”

A gunfight between terrorists and security forces erupted on July 4 in Shopian. At least two terrorists were spotted in the area. Since then, the security forces continued the operation in the area.

NCW seeks report on rape of minor in Rajasthan

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The National Commission for Women (NCW) has taken “serious” cognisance of the alleged gang-rape and trafficking of a minor girl in Sri Ganganagar in Rajasthan and directed the District Magistrate and the Superintendent of Police of the district to submit a comprehensive action-taken report within 15 days.

The commission said that such an incident reflects administrative lapses, policing gaps, and inadequate monitoring mechanisms that allowed such criminal activities to continue and sought a crackdown against illegal hotels.

According to the FIR by the local police, a 13-year-old girl was allegedly held captive and gang-raped by more than 30 men. The brutal ordeal took place across several local hotels in the district.

The commission also took serious note of the delay in presenting the victim before the Child Welfare Committee.

Tihar to respond to U.S. national’s plea for ‘American-style diet’

Shisha Mishra
NEW DELHI

The Tihar prison authorities submitted before a Delhi court on Wednesday that they will file a response to a plea by U.S. national Matthew Aaron VanDyke, an accused in a terror conspiracy case being investigated by the National Investigation Agency (NIA), seeking permission to receive “American-style diet” while in judicial custody.

Special Judge Prashant Sharma of Patiala House Court posted the matter for July 21, before which the prison authorities are expected to respond.

In his plea filed through advocates Rohit Dandriyal and Rohit Gour, Mr. VanDyke submitted before the court that he had been on an apparent hunger strike for nearly 50 days and had survived largely on liquids, including soy milk, because of his inability to eat the food available in prison.

“He has lost 13 kg weight in the duration of his hunger strike,” advocate Dandriyal told *The Hindu*.



Matthew VanDyke. GETTY IMAGES

In his petition, it has been contended that the prolonged nutritional deficiency has adversely affected the accused’s health, including a decline in his eyesight, which is attributed to the lack of an adequate and suitable nutritional diet during his continued incarceration.

Emphasising that the request is made purely on humanitarian considerations and is intended solely to safeguard the health of their client while in judicial custody, counsel has submitted that Mr. VanDyke’s family is willing to bear the entire cost of the proposed dietary arrangement and all related expenses.

Press Trust of India
JAKARTA

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, along with Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto, on Wednesday visited the centuries-old iconic Prambanan Temple complex in Yogyakarta, marking the inauguration of a joint conservation project for this UNESCO World Heritage Site.

Mr. Modi described the initiative as a “shining example of the enduring civilisational bonds” between India and Indonesia, rooted in a shared heritage that has connected the people of the two countries for centuries.

The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) will be



Prime Minister Narendra Modi and devotees visiting the Prambanan Temple in Indonesia on Wednesday. AFP/PIB

the lead agency from the Indian side for the joint restoration project.

Later in the day, Mr. Modi reached Australia on the second leg of his three-nation tour during which he will hold talks with his Aus-

ED freezes ₹440 cr. in Trinamool’s bank accounts amid row

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has frozen three bank accounts of the Trinamool Congress with deposits worth ₹440 crore.

A press statement by the ED stated that the Central agency had conducted search operations at five premises in and around Kolkata under the provisions of Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, belonging to Carewell Group of companies operating in the aviation sector.

“During searches, balances amounting to ₹440.42 crore lying in three HDFC bank accounts of AITC have been frozen under Section 17(1A) of PMLA, 2002,” the press statement added.

The agency said that searches were conducted in connection with an investigation under PMLA, 2002 based on a FIR lodged by the Cyber Police, Bidhannagar, West Bengal in the matter of alleged dis-

honest financial dealings, unlawful collection of money, and routing of suspected funds through certain bank accounts of Trinamool Congress.

Factions lay claim

Both factions of the Trinamool Congress, one led by former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and another led by Leader of the Opposition Ritabrata Banerjee, have claimed ownership over the accounts. The Kolkata Police have asked the banks to freeze the three accounts. The Calcutta High Court, which is hearing the matter, had raised questions on what was the tearing hurry in freezing the bank accounts.

The ED said that investigation revealed that around ₹160 crore was transferred from Trinamool Congress bank accounts to M/s Carewell Aviation India Pvt. Ltd. and its related entity, between April 2023 to June 2026. The firm routed ₹82.96 crore for purchasing an aircraft and a helicopter.

Calcutta HC seeks affidavit on midday meal contract

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

The Calcutta High Court on Wednesday directed the West Bengal government to file an affidavit after the State said that no decision had yet been taken on entrusting the PM-POSHAN (midday meal) scheme in Kolkata schools to ISKCON (International Society for Krishna Consciousness).

The direction was passed by a Division Bench of Acting Chief Justice Tapabrata Chakraborty and Justice Partha Sarathi Chatterjee while hearing a public interest litigation (PIL) filed by advocate Sirsanya Bandopadhyay challenging the proposal to hand over the responsibility of food preparation to ISKCON.

Shah orders audit to reduce passenger delays at airports

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Union Home Minister Amit Shah has directed the Ministry of Civil Aviation and the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) to independently commission third-party studies during the peak travel season to identify and reduce passenger delays across all touch points at major airports.

The direction came during a review meeting with Union Civil Aviation Minister K. Rammohan Naidu on passenger facilities, security arrangements and the immigration system at major airports. The meeting was attended by the Union Home Secretary, Director of the Intelligence Bureau, Secretary of the Ministry of Civil Aviation, Director-General of the CISF, Chairman of the Airports Authority of India and other senior officials.

To improve passenger processing, Mr. Shah directed the phased installation of an automatic tray retrieval system (ATRS) at airports across the coun-



Amit Shah. ANI

try, to ease the congestion at security checkpoints and reduce manpower requirements.

He also asked the Ministry of Civil Aviation to prescribe norms for the number of aerobridges at airports based on passenger and aircraft traffic. In addition, the baggage drop facility, currently available at 16 major airports, will be expanded to other international airports handling high passenger volumes.

To speed up immigration clearance, Mr. Shah also called for greater adoption of the Centre’s Fast Track Immigration-Trusted Travellers’ Programme (FTI-TTP).

AAP faces heat after U.S. names inspector in an ‘extortion plot’

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

The political atmosphere in Punjab charged up on Wednesday after the U.S. Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) named Punjab Police inspector Gurinderjit Singh Nagra in an alleged international extortion plot.

The Opposition parties cornered the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), terming the episode a reflection of complete breakdown of law and order in the State.

Congress leader Vijay Inder Singla said the revelations from the FBI’s “Operation Hard Ball” exposed a state-gangster nexus thriving right under the nose of the AAP government. “The FBI has charged Gurinderjit Singh Nagra, Station House Officer of the Tanda police station, in a \$400,000 extortion case for allegedly working hand-in-glove with the Lawrence Bishnoi and Jaggu Bhagwanpuria syndicates to terrorise innocent families,” he said.

Mr. Singla added that while global law enforcement was aggressively hunting down these criminals, the law and order apparatus had completely collapsed in Punjab.

Former Minister and Shiromani Akali Dal leader



If the FBI takes this inspector to the U.S., the alleged AAP, gangster, and Punjab Police nexus will be exposed before the world

BIKRAM SINGH MAJITHIA
SAD leader

Bikram Singh Majithia said that “...If the FBI takes this inspector to the United States, the alleged AAP, gangster, and Punjab Police nexus will be exposed before the world, something many have been demanding.”

‘Failed to deliver’

BJP Punjab unit president Kewal Singh Dhillon said the people of Punjab were demanding answers from a government that promised “change” but failed to deliver. “Countless families have been devastated by drugs, gun violence and murders, yet the government continues to remain indifferent,” he alleged in a statement.

Mr. Dhillon said Punjab could only be rescued from the present crisis through stringent laws and a zero-tolerance policy against criminals, without which lasting peace could not be restored.

Bishnoi, aides used WhatsApp from jail to threaten victims: U.S.

U.S. DoJ echoes NIA’s 2022 chargesheet; it says Bishnoi’s ‘enterprise routinely targeted prominent religious, social, political leaders with violence’; his lawyer says ‘authorities should give supporting evidence’ of gangster using messaging apps

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The U.S. Department of Justice (DoJ) said on Wednesday that Lawrence Bishnoi, a Punjab-born gangster currently lodged in a high-security prison in Ahmedabad, Gujarat, used WhatsApp and other encrypted messaging applications as recently as December 2025 and January 2026 to allegedly extort and attempt to extort \$5 million from victims in Los Angeles and Thousand Oaks in the U.S.

The DoJ has accused him and his associate Sattinderjeet Singh, alias Goldy Brar, of ordering the assassination of pro-Khalistani activist Hardeep Singh Nijjar. It said the “enterprise routinely targeted prominent religious, social, and political leaders with violence, and used these high-profile acts to terrorise and extort members of the community”.

For instance, in November 2023, Bishnoi claimed responsibility for a shooting that occurred at the Vancouver, Canada, residence of a prominent Indian actor and singer, and warned in a Facebook post



Serious charges: Lawrence Bishnoi is currently lodged at Sabarmati jail in Ahmedabad. FILE PHOTO

written in Punjabi that “no one can save you from us”.

According to his lawyer Rajni Khatri, Bishnoi is lodged at Sabarmati jail since 2023 in solitary confinement and is under 24/7 CCTV surveillance. The Union Home Ministry has invoked Section 303 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, which prohibits his movement outside the jail, and he participates in court hearings through videoconference. If police from outside the State have to interrogate him, they come to the prison.

According to a chargesheet filed by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in

2022 against Bishnoi and others, he has 84 cases registered against him in Delhi, Chandigarh, Rajasthan, and Punjab with the first case dating back to 2010.

Ms. Khatri said that Bishnoi has been discharged or acquitted in 40 other cases. “If he was using WhatsApp to carry out the extortion activities from jail, then authorities should give supporting evidence. He is under 24/7 surveillance in the prison. He only meets his legal team,” she said. Before Sabarmati, Bishnoi was lodged for a year in a Punjab jail and in Delhi’s Tihar jail prior to that.

There was no response

from State or Union government officials on the allegations made by the U.S. authorities.

NIA chargesheet

The NIA’s chargeheet echoed the allegations made by the U.S. DoJ about Bishnoi running his racket from the prison. The DoJ said that by “using contra-band cellphones and other voice-over Internet protocol devices smuggled into his jail cell, Bishnoi personally directed political assassinations, murders, shootings, extortions, kidnappings, drug trafficking, human smuggling, and other crimes committed by members and associates of the Bishnoi enterprise worldwide”.

In 2022, the NIA had said that Bishnoi “runs the entire operations of the gang from within the jail”. “He is so adept in operating from inside the jail that he has not applied bail in any case since last many years,” it had said.

But Ms. Khatri said Bishnoi did not apply for bail in the recent years as there are several cases registered against him and no one will come forward to secure a bail-bond for him. For instance, the NIA

chargesheet cited the conspiracy to murder Sidhu Moosewala. It stated that during the planning and execution of the killing, key accused persons were lodged in different prisons, including Bishnoi and Jaggu Bhagwanpuria in Tihar, Manpreet in Ferozepur jail, Saraj Singh Mantoo in Bathinda jail and Manmohan Singh in Mansa jail. Despite being incarcerated, they allegedly remained in communication with Brar, who coordinated with the jailed associates, and eventually tasked the shooters with carrying out the killing after Moosewala’s security cover was reduced, the NIA had said.

The NIA had said that a considerable part of money generated through extortion activities is sent to Canada, the U.S., Dubai, Thailand, and Australia for the use of their foreign-based associates and family members, and also for funding the activities of “pro-Khalistan extremists”.

The NIA had said that assisted by associates including Goldy Brar, Bishnoi allegedly expanded his network into a large criminal organisation.

Congress appoints new in-charge for Tamil Nadu, West Bengal

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Wednesday appointed new All India Congress Committee (AICC) in-charge for Tamil Nadu and West Bengal as part of the party’s ongoing organisational reshuffle.

A statement from AICC general secretary (organisation) K. C. Venugopal said Gulam Ahmed Mir is the new AICC general secretary in-charge of Tamil Nadu in place of Girish Chodankar.

Mr. Mir was earlier the in-charge of West Bengal. Now, Prakash Joshi has been appointed in his place for the State.

On June 26, the party appointed new AICC in-charge for Uttar Pradesh, Odisha, and Haryana. While Sanjay Dutt replaced B. K. Hariprasad as the new Haryana in-charge, Mr. Hariprasad was appointed the new Karnataka Congress in-charge.

Lalji Desai became the new AICC in-charge for Odisha, replacing Ajay Kumar Lallu.

Rajendra Pal Gautam, who heads the Scheduled Caste department of the party, was named the new in-charge for Uttar Pradesh.

BJP govt. has lost credibility on all fronts, says SP chief

The Hindu Bureau
LUCKNOW

Opposition leaders in Uttar Pradesh hit out at the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party on Wednesday, claiming that the State government has completely lost its religious, cultural, political, and economic credibility in the wake of the allegations about embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya.

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav claimed that the disrepute affects Hindu devotees around the world and is leading to a withdrawal of funds by global investors.

“This incident has enraged the Sanatan community worldwide, as not only the religion but also the country is suffering disrepute due to the BJP’s unrighteousness,” Mr. Yadav said in a post on X.

Uttar Pradesh Congress Committee president Ajay Rai wrote a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, demanding accountability over the embezzlement issue.

Cong. seeks Champat Rai’s arrest, asks PM to apologise over temple donation row

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Wednesday demanded the immediate arrest of former Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust general secretary Champat Rai and sought an apology from Prime Minister Narendra Modi over his “mistake” in selecting Trust members.

As part of the principal Opposition party’s continued focus on the issue of alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, senior Congress leader Shaktisinh Gohil addressed a press conference here. Mr. Gohil reiterated the party’s demand for a Supreme Court-monitored investigation into the alleged irregularities and called for the immediate dissolution of the Trust.

“The Trust should be immediately dissolved and replaced by a new Trust. The composition of this new Trust should be decided collectively by the Shankaracharyas, a retired Su-



Shaktisinh Gohil

preme Court judge, representatives of the Nir-mohi Akhara, and various seers and saints,” the Congress leader said.

Mr. Modi ought to apologise to the country for his “mistake” in inducting people such as Mr. Rai into the Trust, instead of seers and saints, Mr. Gohil said.

‘Diversion of funds’

The pattern of donations at the temple had raised serious questions about the possible diversion of funds, the Congress leader also alleged.

“Before the issue of theft of donations from the Ram Temple came to light,

daily collections amounted to ₹16 lakh to ₹18 lakh. After the matter became public, this figure rose to ₹24 lakh to ₹26 lakh per day,” Mr. Gohil claimed, adding that this gave rise to the suspicion that around ₹10 lakh a day may have been misappropriated earlier.

Describing the temple as a matter of faith for crores of people, Mr. Gohil said any alleged financial irregularity linked to it could not be tolerated.

Later, Congress leader Jairam Ramesh sharpened the party’s political attack on the Prime Minister, saying Mr. Modi had been at the forefront in taking credit for the Ram Temple but was now “shying away” from taking responsibility for the alleged theft of donations.

“The Congress demands: dissolve the Trust, arrest the real culprits, conduct an investigation under Supreme Court supervision, form a new Trust and apologise to the nation. Modi ji, break your silence,” he said on X.

Donation racket alleged at temple in Madhya Pradesh; probe ordered

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

The Madhya Pradesh authorities have formed an investigation committee to probe an alleged “parallel donation” racket, fraud, and financial irregularities that have come to light at the famous Maa Baglamukhi Temple in Nalkhedra in Agar Malwa district, officials said.

The temple is managed by a government committee. It is alleged that a parallel, “unauthorised committee” was operating on the temple premises, accepting donations made in cash and valuable ornaments, by issuing fake receipts.

District Collector Preeti Yadav on Tuesday formed a three-member committee. The report is to be submitted within seven days. According to Ms. Yadav’s order, complaints have been received of financial irregularities by a non-governmental committee, which was allegedly collecting donations separately from the official committee, and using private bank accounts.

It has been tasked with probing the amount of cash and jewellery received, and whether any employee or official of the temple administration was involved in the alleged fraud. The amount of fraud is yet to be calculated, the authorities said. “It could be a significant amount since it looks like an organised racket with receipts and counters,” a district administration official told *The Hindu*.

No change in Punjab Congress leadership, Warring will continue as unit chief: Baghel

Vikas Vasudeva
CHANDIGARH

Amid the ongoing power tussle in the Punjab Congress, the party’s State in-charge, Bhupesh Baghel, on Wednesday ruled out the possibility of leadership change, asserting that Amarinder Singh Raja Warring would continue as the Punjab Congress president, even as party leaders were making efforts to resolve the ongoing issues through dialogue.

Mr. Baghel’s remark came at a time when internal strife surrounding pow-



Bhupesh Baghel

er control within the Punjab Congress has been intensifying ahead of the 2027 Assembly polls.

“When the [party] high command takes a decision, it is not changed,” said Mr.

Baghel, responding to presspersons on the possibility of a change in the State leadership. Asserting that repeatedly changing the decision surrounding the leadership was not a child’s play, he said Mr. Warring would continue as Punjab Pradesh Congress president.

Unit revamped

On July 1, the All India Congress Committee revamped the Punjab unit. While Mr. Warring was retained as the PPCC chief, former Chief Minister Charanjit Singh Channi was ap-

pointed to lead the campaign committee ahead of the Assembly elections. Mr. Channi, a Lok Sabha member, is believed to be upset with the revamp. He, along with a faction of his supporters, reportedly had been pressing for a meeting with the party’s central leadership. Mr. Baghel said he would soon meet Mr. Channi.

Meanwhile, Congress MP Gurjeet Singh Aujla met Mr. Channi and pointed out that senior party leaders were making efforts to resolve the ongoing issues through dialogue.

Improved rain will boost kharif sowing: Agriculture Minister

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

After a high-level meeting here on Wednesday to review the El Niño conditions, Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said the monsoon situation in the country had improved.

The overall rainfall deficit, after recording a 33% deficit in June, had reduced to 24% in July. He said the Centre was closely monitoring the situation.

He exuded confidence that rainfall would gain further momentum during July, leading to an acceleration in kharif sowing. Kharif sowing had so far been completed on 350.85 lakh hectares, approximately 91.95 lakh hectares lower than in the corresponding period last year, he said.



GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA

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email : serwsbd2003@yahoo.com

Letter No.: 3199

Date:07/07/2026

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3. Estimated Cost : Various from Rs.104.86 Lakhs to Rs.443.38 Lakhs (Approximately)

4. Details of projects : As per Annexure attached.

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender online for bidding		Last Date & Time of seeking tender clarification	Date & Time of opening of tender	
		From	To		Technical Bid	Financial Bids
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Sunabeda	CCERWCSBD - Online - 27/2026-27	10.07.2026 at 11.00 A.M.	28.07.2026 up to 05.00 P.M.	27.07.2026 up to 2.00 P.M.	29.07.2026 at 11.00 A.M.	To be intimated separately

5. The details of works can be seen from the web site : <https://www.tendersodisha.gov.in>

6. Any Corrigendum / Addendum will be displayed in the above e-tender web site.

Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Sunabeda.

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INBRIEF



MSIL starts Battery Energy Storage System at Kharkhoda

Maruti Suzuki India Ltd. (MSIL) has announced the commissioning of a 1 MWh Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) at its Kharkhoda manufacturing facility. In 2025, the company had installed a 20 MWp solar power project at this facility. The BESS will help in storing excess electricity generated during low-demand periods or facility holidays and make it available for use when required, MSIL said. In addition, it would help improve grid stability. As a pilot initiative, BESS has been integrated into the Kharkhoda facility's internal electricity distribution network.

PGIM MF pauses subscription to three international funds

PGIM Mutual Fund (MF) said it had suspended subscription to three of its international funds temporarily in order to comply with SEBI's cap on overseas investment. Announcements that fresh subscriptions into PGIM India Global Equity Opportunities Fund of Fund, PGIM India Emerging Markets Equity Fund of Fund, and PGIM India Global Select Real Estate Securities Fund of Fund (FoF) were already made earlier in March and June 2026. Accordingly, the subscriptions for SIPs into those schemes will not be available beginning July 9, the Asset Management Company (AMC) said in a notice.

AI company UST ropes in Anthropic to adopt Claude

UST, an AI and technology transformation solutions company, on Wednesday, entered into a strategic alliance with Anthropic, an AI safety and research company that developed the Claude family of models. According to a UST communique, the partnership is focused on helping Global 1,000 enterprises become AI-native. UST will embed Claude into the engineering environments and operational workflows it designs, builds, and runs for clients, helping organisations move from isolated AI pilots to trusted, enterprise-scale AI embedded in the systems that drive their business. UST is making a significant investment in AI by training and certifying 20,000 associates worldwide.

‘TRAI’s attempt to regulate Truecaller makes ‘no sense’

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

Truecaller hit out against the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) for reportedly trying to bring the caller ID firm under regulation. The move comes months into TRAI's mandate that promotional and banking calls respectively use 140- and 160-series numbers and apps such as Truecaller whitelist these numbers from spam warnings.

While Truecaller was doubtful of TRAI's authority to order apps – as opposed to telcos – to whitelist such numbers, it deferred to the instructions. Now, the firm says, the whitelisting has led to a “significant” increase in spam calls. Truecaller CEO Rishit Jhunjhunwala wrote on X, formerly Twitter, that “[o]ver 51 million calls from both series go unanswered every single day,” and “[t]his happened in front of our eyes and we are mandated not to tell users those calls are spam.”

As the number of such calls blocked by Truecaller users mounted to over one lakh a day, Mr. Jhunjhunwala said, “We said enough is enough,” and “built the ‘Frequently Blocked’ badge,” which was displayed even on whitelisted numbers. Banks have been using the series, sanctioned by TRAI earlier this month, to reach out to customers with loan, credit and other offers.



Rishit Jhunjhunwala

Mr. Jhunjhunwala's riposte on X came a day after a financial daily reported TRAI took exception to the labelling of calls from this series and wrote to the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) seeking the authority to regulate caller ID apps. MeitY, whose remit includes regulation of online services, did not respond to a request for comment. Neither did TRAI.

App regulation

Multiple Ministries within the government have gradually asserted themselves into private platforms' platform design over the last few months. Last year, the Department of Telecommunications (DoT), which regulates telecom operators and Internet service providers, issued directions to WhatsApp that would require the messaging app to only work if the registered SIM card was currently inside the phone of a user. MeitY, on the other

Indices dip 2% amid renewed U.S.-Iran tension in West Asia

U.S. withdraws from the ceasefire; Brent crude futures spike by 74% in two sessions, trading at more than \$77.3 a barrel; Rupee tanks 52 paise to settle at 95.48 against the U.S. dollar

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Benchmark Nifty and Sensex dipped over 2% to 23,882.05 and 76,503.60 points respectively after renewed Iran-U.S. clashes sent global oil prices soaring on Wednesday.

The indices opened about 0.6% down from the previous close and declined slowly until 2 p.m., after which both tumbled to the day's close.

Brent crude futures spiked by 7.4% in two sessions, trading at more than \$77.3 a barrel on Wednesday, as compared with \$72 a barrel on Monday. This, however, is nowhere close



Crash course: The indices opened about 0.6% down from the previous close and tumbled to the day's close. PAUL NORONHA

to the levels between March and April, when the war escalated almost everyday. “I think it's over. I don't want to deal with them any more, they're scum,” U.S. President Trump said when asked if

the ceasefire with Iran was over, at the NATO summit at Turkey on Wednesday. News reports on the U.S. President's remarks sent global markets crashing. “Elevated crude oil prices bear negatively on In-

dia, the world's third-largest importer and consumer of oil, as they inflate the import bill, stoke inflationary pressures, and weigh on the trajectory of economic growth,” said Nandish Shah, deputy vice president, HDFC Securities. The rupee tanked 52 paise to settle at 95.48 against the U.S. dollar on Wednesday.

“Geopolitical concerns have lifted the risk premium amid heightened volatility. In the near term, USD-INR is expected to face resistance at 95.80 and support at 94.95, with the bias now favouring dollar bulls,” said Dilip Parmar, Research Analyst, HDFC Securities.

MRPL said to cancel West Asia vessel charter

Reuters
NEW DELHI

Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals has cancelled a vessel charter it had booked for loading crude oil from Iraq, two sources with knowledge of the matter said.

One of them said MRPL has cited “technical reasons” for not going ahead with the chartering of the Aframax tanker Jasmin Joy.

It was not clear whether the chartering failed due to heightened tension in the Strait of Hormuz, the sources said, after attacks on some ships in the key waterway prompted maritime authorities to raise the threat risk for transit-ing vessels to “severe”.

Tata Motors PV eyes 20% market share by 2031, says Chairman

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Having grown from the sixth position in the Indian passenger vehicles segment to the number two player in 2026 in six years, Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Ltd. is now aiming for a 20% market share and an annual sales volume of over 1.2 million vehicles in five years, said Chairman N. Chandrasekaran.

“Looking at this decade of transformation from FY20 to FY31: we will grow the business by 10x. Our ambition is to scale to over 1.2 million annual sales, achieve 20% market share and double-digit EBITDA margin,” said Mr. Chandrasekaran on Wednesday ad-

Over the past six years the domestic PV business had grown nearly five times in volumes

dressings shareholders at the company's AGM.

He said the company would strengthen its portfolio with the launch of six new nameplates and over 20 product refreshes and make electric vehicles (EV) contribute more than 30% of its sales volumes.

The Chairman said over the past six years (FY20-26) the domestic passenger vehicle business had grown nearly five times in volumes and close to six times in revenue.

SEBI amends registration fee rule for FPIs

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Markets regulator SEBI has replaced the existing U.S. dollar-denominated registration fee for Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) with a rupee-based fee structure and has amended the rules governing FPIs.

SEBI has revised the registration fee for Category-I FPIs from \$2,500 to ₹2.3 lakh. Similarly, registration fee for FPIs belonging to Category II has been revised from \$250 to ₹23,000. Application fee for general relaxations or exemptions from strict enforcement of regulations is revised from \$1,000 to ₹90,000 in eligible foreign exchange equivalent.

India added 52.5 mtpa regasification capacity in 2025: IGU World LNG Report

Santosh V. Perumal
CHENNAI

India added 52.5 million tonnes per annum (mtpa) of regasification capacity across eight terminals, as it surpassed Spain to become the fourth largest market for regasification capacity in 2025, according to the International Gas Union's (IGU) World LNG Report.

Rising demand for fertilizer, city gas and utilities as well as the government's push for enhanced share of liquefied natural gas (LNG) in the energy mix was seen helping the country.

Among operational LNG regasification terminals in India, Dahej LNG (17.5 mtpa) stands out as the only ultra-large facility and ranks as the sixth largest globally.



Dahej LNG terminal ranks as the sixth largest globally.

pansion projects at existing facilities, including the expansion of India's largest terminal, Dahej LNG.

Once commissioned, these projects are expected to add a combined 11.3 mtpa of regasification capacity by 2028.

According to the International Energy Agency, India's natural gas consumption is forecast to increase by nearly 60% by 2030, driven by robust growth in city gas distribution, industrial demand, and power generation.

India's LNG regasification utilisation fell to about 47% in 2025, down from 58% in 2024, reflecting a combination of weaker LNG imports during the summer months and an increase in regasification capacity following recent infrastructure additions.

Asia led the global LNG regasification capacity additions in 2025, with all new capacity coming from China and India, contributing 15.1 mtpa and 7.1 mtpa, representing 24% and 11.3% of global additions, respectively.

Although the Asia Pacific remained the largest LNG-importing region, IGU found imports into Asia fell by 9.2 MT to 108.7 MT, driven mainly by lower intake in China and India.

KALYAN SINGH SUPER SPECIALTY CANCER INSTITUTE

C.G. City, Sultanpur Road, Lucknow-226002
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TENDER NOTICE
Offers are invited through GeM bidding from Original Equipment Manufacture/Direct Importers/Authorized Distributors (declared by principal firm only) for the supply & installation of various Medical Equipment/Items for the various departments of the Institute.

The Vendors are required to submit their offers on GeM portal only in two bids system i.e. Technical and Financial bid as per norms of GeM Portal.

For more detailed information you may please visit the GeM portal www.gem.gov.in. The list of the equipment will also be available on our website <https://cancerinstitute.edu.in> for reference only. The offer will be accepted only on GeM portal with terms and conditions as mentioned against bidding documents.

The Director reserves the right to accept or reject any tender in part or full without assigning any reason thereof.

Advt No. KSSSCI/Tender-08/2026-27 Joint DIRECTOR (MM)

U.T. OF LAKSHADWEEP
LAKSHADWEEP DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED
(A GOVT. OF INDIA UNDERTAKING)
Ph: 04842323448/458 E-mail: aminidivi@asianetindia.com
F.No: LDCLWO/2026-2 Dt : 27.06.2026

TENDER NOTICE
E-tenders are hereby invited from eligible contractors empanelled under the existing Rate Contract for the work of removal and sale of waste oil generated onboard twenty-two (22) vessels of the Union Territory of Lakshadweep Administration (UTLA), operated by Lakshadweep Development Corporation Limited (LDCL), in accordance with the terms and conditions stipulated in the tender document.

Tender Reference No.: LDCL/WO/2026-2
Last Date & Time for Submission: 15.07.2026 at 03:00 PM
The detailed tender documents, including scope of work, eligibility criteria, and terms and conditions, are available on the official e-procurement portal at <https://tendersutl.gov.in>
For any assistance related to the e-tendering process, bidders may contact the Help Desk at 0120-4001002, 0120-4001005, or 0120-6277787.
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No. :- F. / (RKVY/SABI)/2026/36 Date :- 03/07/2026

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For more details please visit our website <https://www.sknaui.ac.in/sabi>. Last date to receive online applications is tentatively 31st July 2026.
Raj.Samwad/C/26/6378 P.I. (S-ABI), SKNAU, Jobner

KERALA WATER AUTHORITY
RE - E-TENDER NOTICE

Re-Tender No. 03/2026-27/SE/PPD/KCH
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Cost of Tender form:Rs. 19,518/- (inclusive of GST); EMD:Rs. 500,000/- ; Date and time of Opening Tender: 03/08/2026 3.30 pm ; Last date of receipt of tender: 01/08/2026 3.00 pm; Phone:8547638502 ; E-mail- seppd.kochicorpn@gmail.com
Sd/-, Superintending Engineer, PPDU & Sewerage Circle, KWA, Kochi - 11

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SCO 74-75, BANK SQUARE, SECTOR-17B CHANDIGARH
PBX: 0172-5197847, 5197846

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
PSWC invites online tenders through GeM Portal for creation of 1.75 LMT godown capacities at 06 locations in the State of Punjab for guaranteed lease of 10 years on Build, Own and Operate/Lease basis for storage requirements of FCI under two bid system 'Technical Bid' and 'Financial Bid'.
NIT (alongwith GeM Bid IDs) is available on Department's website i.e. <https://pswc.in>
PSWC reserves the right to scrap the tender at any stage without assigning any reason and PSWC will not be held liable for any costs and consequences incurred by the intending bidders.

Note: Any corrigendum(s)/Notification(s) to this Notice Inviting E-Tender shall be published Department's website & GeM Portal.
1004/12/2026-27/13074 Managing Director, PSWC

BENGALURU SOUTH CITY CORPORATION
Office of the Executive Engineer,
Padmanabhanagara Division, Opp. to Sagar Hospitals,
Kumaraswamy Layout, Bengaluru-560 111.

No: EE(PN)/TEND/04/2026-27 Date: 08.07.2026

TENDER NOTIFICATION
(Through GOK KPPP only) (Two Cover System)
website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

The Executive Engineer, Padmanabhanagara Division, BSCC, Bengaluru invites tenders from eligible contractors registered in Greater Bengaluru Authority (Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike) or equivalent registration with CPWD / KPWD / Railways / MES or any State Government Organizations for the constructions of work detailed in the table below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1.	Resurfacing / Providing Concrete to existing roads, Improvements to drains and footpath in Ward No-180 Banashankari Temple Ward. (2nd Call) Approximate Amount put to Tender (₹ in Lakhs) 200.00, EMD Amount in ₹: 3,00,000/-

Calendar of Events: (1) Date of down loading of tender documents: **09.07.2026.** (2) Last date for submission queries of **17.07.2026 within 3:00 p.m.** (3) Pre bid meeting will be held on **17.07.2026 at 4:00 p.m.** in the Office of the Chief Engineer, Jayanagar Zone (Zone-1), BSCC, 9th Main, 9th Cross, Jayangara 2nd Block, Bengaluru-560 011. (4) Last Date & Time for receipt of tenders: **23.07.2026 up to 4:00 p.m.** (5) Date & Time for Opening Technical bid: **24-07-2026 at 4:05 p.m.** (6) Date & Time for Opening Financial bid: **After the approval of Technical Bid.**

Sd/- Executive Engineer, Padmanabhanagara Division, BSCC.

Trump's Board of Peace planning pilot 'humanitarian zone' in Gaza



Funeral processions begin in Najaf for Iran's Ayatollah Ali Khamenei



Drone strikes on civilian vehicles kill 20 in Sudan, say rights groups



'U.S. will give Ukraine licence to produce Patriot defence systems'



Ukraine says its drones hit 3 refineries and tankers

Indian national among inmates killed in Sri Lanka's prison riots

Trump blasts NATO for rejecting efforts to claim Greenland

Is the U.S.-Iran ceasefire agreement falling apart?

 $\Delta \text{CH-CH}_2$

Ruthless Kostyuk packs off Paolini, sets up last-four clash with Noskova

Second seed Zverev makes short work of Fritz; wildcard Fery continues dream run; Arnav enters boys' quarterfinal

WIMBLEDON
N. Sudarshan
LONDON

Centre Court at Wimbledon barely sleeps. Less than 15 hours after Novak Djokovic and Felix Auger-Aliassime put on a five-hour, 15-minute classic, Marta Kostyuk and Jasmine Paolini were out there for their women's quarterfinal. Wednesday's fixture, much to the disappointment of the fans, didn't live up to being a worthy follow-up, as Kostyuk thrashed Paolini 6-3, 6-2 in one hour and nine minutes. But it is a result that will suit the 12th seed just fine, for she will have to return on Thursday for her last-four clash versus the ninth seed from Czechia Linda Noskova, who beat Belgium's Elise Mertens 6-3, 7-5. Ahead of her second straight Major semifinal, Kostyuk might also be secretly happy that she spent 40 minutes less than Noskova on court. During the unrelenting summer, every little edge matters. Among advantages, the



Serving it up: Kostyuk never gave Paolini an opportunity to break. AP

24-year-old can also count her quality of tennis. The Ukrainian was ruthless against her Italian opponent, winning 90% of her first-serve points, 67% of the seconds, and did not allow a single chance to break. In the opening set, Kostyuk broke in the fifth and ninth games. In the second set, she moved swiftly towards shutting down the contest by going up 3-1. Paolini, finalist in 2024, loosened up a tad and swung a couple of shots freely. But at 30-30, Kostyuk served a bullet down the T to which the 13th

seed had no answer. Kostyuk soon led 5-2 to leave Paolini on the brink. And such was her tearing hurry that she didn't even wait for the opportunity to serve it out. Two excellent backhand winners in the eighth game showed her resolve, and a third from the same wing breached Paolini's defence on match-point. "Hello Centre Court!," said Kostyuk in her victory speech. "It is my first time here and dream come true. My coach made me walk here and I was flabbergasted by everything inside.

"I sat beside [the honour board] and took a moment to soak it all in. I am soaking it all in again now after the win," she added. Just like the women's section, the two men's last-eight matches also finished in straight-sets. Second seed and Roland-Garros champion Alexander Zverev got past Taylor Fritz 6-4, 6-4, 6-2 to enter his maiden Wimbledon semifinal. He will meet British wildcard Arthur Fery, who overcame Flavio Cobolli 6-4, 7-6(4), 6-0. Fritz, the sixth seed, later said that he was troubled by tendinitis in his

QUARTERFINAL RESULTS
Men: 2-Zverev (Ger) bt 6-Fritz (USA) 6-4, 6-4, 6-2; Fery (GBR) bt 9-Cobolli (Ita) 6-4, 7-6(4), 6-0; 7-Djokovic (Srb) bt 3-Auger-Aliassime (Can) 7-6(10), 3-6, 6-3, 6-7(4), 7-6 [10-4]. Women: 9-Noskova (Cze) bt 25-Mertens (Bel) 6-3, 7-5; 12-Kostyuk (Ukr) bt 13-Paolini (Ita) 6-3, 6-2.

right knee three games into the tie but also credited Zverev for playing superlative tennis. Cobolli, the 2026 French Open finalist, hinted at having underestimated Fery. In boys' singles, India's Arnav Vijay Paparkar brushed aside Japan's Ryo Tabata 6-2, 6-1 to enter the quarterfinals. Tabata started with a strapping on his left knee, and called for the physio before serving at 2-3. Arnav, 18, capitalised by breaking Tabata twice to win the first set. In the second, Tabata's movement was severely compromised and the reverse in 52 minutes was barely a surprise. However, Arnav and his Thai partner Kunanan Pantaratorn fell to an agonising 6-3, 5-7, [16-18] second round defeat in doubles to Brazil's Luis Guto Miguel and Croatia's Ziga Sesko.

Djokovic, all of 39, keeps redefining his career graph

N. Sudarshan
LONDON

In tennis parlance, 39 years is when your career is in its autumn. But for Novak Djokovic, it is proving to be a glorious second summer. History-making and record-setting are like second nature to him. Yet, his performance on Tuesday, under the dazzling white lights of Centre Court and against an opponent nearly 14 years his junior, was astonishing to say the least. The Serbian great finished on the right side of a five-hour, 15-minute slugfest to oust third seed Felix Auger-Aliassime 7-6(10), 3-6, 6-3, 6-7(4), 7-6 [10-4] and set up a much-anticipated last-four meeting with World No. 1 and defending champion Jannik Sinner. Djokovic has now reached eight straight singles semifinals at Wimbledon. It is also his 15th overall at the All England Club, equalling Roger Federer and Rafael Nadal's single-Slam records at the Australian Open and French Open respectively. In a fantastic coincidence, Djokovic was early in the first-set tie-break when fellow 39-year-old Lionel Messi was fashioning a thrilling 3-2 World Cup win for Argentina over Egypt in Atlanta.



Supreme fitness: Djokovic displayed tenacity during a marathon.

Asked about it in the post-match press conference, the seven-time Wimbledon titlist quipped: "It would be nice to play 90 minutes like him." That Djokovic was on the court for three hours and 45 minutes more - albeit in a less explosive and non-contact sport - was testament to his incredible fitness and supreme conditioning. Djokovic's ship did not always sail smoothly. He experienced discomfort in his left leg as early as the ninth game and called for a medical time-out. There were multiple occasions when he grimaced between points. He also seemed out of breath after many a long-drawn rally. But he made it look enjoyable, letting out a wry smile from time to time. It was an evening of undulating fortunes; Auger-Aliassime had set-points in the first stanza but did not

capitalise; Djokovic was up a break in the fourth and yet allowed the match to drift into a decider. But the 24-time Major winner was flawless when it was most required - in the 10-point match-tie-break where he barely missed a shot. It was a textbook example of how elites quarantine themselves and elevate their play. As Djokovic later mentioned, it was all about "management of nerves and the extreme tension". "These are the moments I still play tennis for," Djokovic said, after the longest Wimbledon quarterfinal. "I wish it was the final so that I didn't have to worry about how the body will feel. "I was telling the kids to go to sleep after the fourth set but they didn't listen. I am glad they stayed because it was one of my best matches on this court".



Time to regroup: India will be hoping to bounce back from the T20 World Cup disappointment. X@BCCIWOMEN

Test cricket is exciting and brings different challenges: Muzumdar

INDIA IN ENGLAND
P.K. Ajith Kumar
LONDON

Amol Muzumdar was playing in Yorkshire when Mohammad Azharuddin's Indian team toured England in 1996. He travelled from up north to watch the second Test, in which two young batters made their debut: Sourav Ganguly and Rahul Dravid. Ganguly made 131 and Dravid 95. Muzumdar still remembers watching that sublime hundred by Ganguly from the Compton Stand. Come Friday, Muzumdar will get a better view of a Lord's Test. And he is not just going to be a spectator. He is the coach of the Indian team that is playing the first-ever Women's Test at Lord's.

He said the team was excited about the occasion.

"It just boggles my mind that it is the first Women's Test match here at Lord's. It is a great occasion, and we are looking forward to it." India is playing the Test after the disappointment at the T20 World Cup, which concluded last Sunday. India had bowed out of the competition at the group stage after losing to Australia. "We didn't have the best of World Cups," Muzumdar said. "We were disappointed for sure. I guess we have managed to do that. We had five really good days of preparation, a few days at Wormsley Cricket Club. It is a beautiful ground, just the perfect setting for the preparation." He said traditionally India did well in Test matches and expressed confidence that the players could handle the transition well, though there were

few Tests for women. "But we are playing more Test matches now than we did a few years back," he said. "And red-ball cricket is just about adjustment. If you are a professional cricketer, there is not much of a difference. Test cricket is exciting and it brings different challenges. You have got to bowl 100 overs, mind you. It is a four-day game, and you have to bowl 100 overs in a day. So, I guess, different challenges, different excitement." Priya replaces Pratika During the press conference, Muzumdar confirmed that Pratika Rawal had been ruled out of the Test and replaced by Priya Punia. "Pratika suffered an injury in the India-A match. She has got a cut on her knee which required some stitches".

Lord's Test will be Beaumont's last

P.K. Ajith Kumar
LONDON

Tammy Beaumont, only the second woman to score a hundred in all three formats, is retiring from international cricket. Her last game for England will be the first-ever women's Test at Lord's, against India, starting on Friday. Beaumont has so far scored 7325 runs and 14 centuries in international cricket. An emotional Beaumont said it had been a



Beaumont. GETTY IMAGES

long time coming. "When I was left out of the 20-over World Cup, it was a bit of a blow. I thought it was the right time to move on," she

said. "Telling the girls about my decision was the hardest bit." She regretted that she could play very few Tests. The historic Lord's game would only be her 12th, though she had made her international debut in 2009. Beaumont was glad to see women's cricket evolve so much in her time. "I made my debut in front of five people besides the groundsman... now we will be playing a Test in front of 20,000 potentially."

SNAPSHOTS

Ganguly inducted into ICC's Hall of Fame
NEW DELHI: Sourav Ganguly became the latest Indian to be inducted into the ICC's Hall of Fame. Ganguly's induction takes the number of Indians in the Hall of Fame to 12.



Ganguly. PTI

Indies 499 & 109/0 in 40 overs (John Campbell 51 n.o. Brandon King 51 n.o.). PoM & PoS: Justin Greaves.

Beleagued India has its task cut out
BRISTOL: Faced with selection dilemmas and struggling to adapt in hostile conditions, the Shreyas Iyer-led Indian team has its task cut out when it takes on England in the fourth T20I on Thursday. The match starts at 10 p.m. IST.

Kooij wins fifth stage; Traeen keeps yellow
PAU: Dutch debutant Olav Kooij won the fifth stage of the Tour de France in a chaotic sprint finish after a crash just over 5km from the line. Norway's Torstein Traeen kept the race leader's yellow jersey.

A rare series victory for West Indies
NORTH SOUND: West Indies drew the second Test with Sri Lanka on Tuesday to claim its first series victory in three years in the red ball format. The scores: Sri Lanka 549/9 decl. & 251/9 decl. in 49 overs (Chandimal 71) drew with West

Indian women's compound team in final
MADRID: The Indian compound women's team ensured a medal by reaching the final at the Archery World Cup Stage-4 in Madrid on Wednesday. The team comprising Prithika Pradeep, Chikitha Taniparthi, V. Jyothi Surekha defeated Korea (Kang, Park and Park) 231-228 in the semifinals to set up a title clash with Colombia. The Indian men's team lost to Germany in bronze match.

LIVE TELECAST
Zimbabwe vs Bangladesh: Second ODI, FanCode, 1 p.m. Wimbledon: Star Sports 1, 2, SS Select 1, 2 & JioHotstar, 6 p.m. England vs India: Fourth T20I, Sony Sports Ten 1 & JioHotstar, 10 p.m. FIFA World Cup: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 1.30 a.m. (Friday)

Title-holder U Mumba to take on Dempo Goa in opening tie

UTT
K. Keerthivasan
PANAJI

The first six editions of Ultimate Table Tennis (UTT) made for an eventful, and at times chequered, journey: one marked by world-class competition and the sport's growing international visibility. At the same time, the league has had to contend with franchise instability, a modest spectator following, and unavailability of world's top paddlers, among other challenges. However, the arrival of Butterfly as title sponsor for five years (2026-30) - despite the reduction in the number of teams from eight to seven - has been a major boost. The partnership is a strong endorsement of UTT's long-term potential. It should provide the league with greater financial stability, help sustain its growth and, hopefully, enable it to address some of the problems that have accompanied its journey so far. Holding the league in Goa for the first time presents an opportunity to en-



All set: Players from different franchises pose with the ultimate prize. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

gage with a new fan base. The organisers will be hoping for strong local support and a vibrant atmosphere at the Shyama Prasad Mukherjee Indoor Stadium on Thursday, when two-time champion Dempo Goa Challengers takes on defending champion U Mumba TT in the opening tie. Young squad Goa has assembled one of the youngest squads, with four players aged between 16 and 21 and in contrast to the more experienced title-holder. Yet, Romania's Bernadette Szocs, the tournament's highest-ranked women's player at World No. 25, believes the side has what it takes to challenge for the crown.

"It will not be easy because our team has many young players without much experience. But Alvaro (Robles) and I can help build the team and try to win the title," she said. Diya Chitale, who will represent PBG Pune Jaguars, summed up the appeal of the league. "UTT is always a very fun and amazing tournament. I just try to enjoy the atmosphere and do my best." Review system The seventh edition will also use the Table Tennis Review (TTR) system where incidents like service height, service angle, table edge contact, etc. can be checked. Teams will have a maximum of three unsuccessful reviews per tie.

Aswath becomes India's 98th Grandmaster

CHESS
C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI



Sealing it: Aswath claimed the GM title after an impressive performance in the Pune International event. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Aswath S. needed to win his last three games to achieve the Grandmaster title, and he did so by winning them on demand at the Pune International Round-Robin chess tournament. With an awesome finish in Pune, the 17-year-old Aswath became India's 98th GM after beating Kanan Vaidyanathan (USA) with black pieces in the final round on Wednesday. Admitting that he felt

some pressure going into the final stretch, he told The Hindu: "I did not think about anything else. I just played the game."

The tournament was Aswath's return to classical chess after a break for his Std. X exams. His previous classical event was in De-

cember 2025, when he earned his second GM norm at the First Saturday GM Round-Robin in Budapest, winning the event with 7/9. The first GM norm came earlier in 2025 at the Grenke Open in Germany, where he produced a stand-out performance to triumph in a strong field. His chess journey began at home when he was three. His father, A.C. Shiva, was his first coach. Aswath began playing district-level events at the age of four and said his early success was in an under-7 State event in 2015, where

he scored nine wins in as many rounds. He trains under GM M. Shyam Sundar at Chess Thulir Academy in Chennai now and said "Shyam sir is a great help and we plan ahead of each game." His immediate focus is to improve his Elo rating to 2600 (currently 2517) and overall improvement. Speaking from Serbia, coach Shyam elaborated: "Aswath is a hardworking, disciplined, motivated and determined player. He doesn't have any social media distractions. He is fully focused. I think he will continue to grow".

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PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, JOSEPH Loyed s/o Maria Joseph Selvam born on 08-11-1984 residing at 47, Thamarai street Poomphuzhal Nagar Avadi Chennai 62, have changed my name to Joseph Lloyd M vide affidavit dated 04-07-2026 at Chennai.

OLD AGE HOME

PALLIATIVE CARE at your home Trained Nurses, 24/7, Dr., Physio visits, Lab tests 1800-313-1883 tikotra.com/seniors

PUBLIC NOTICE

PUBLIC NOTICE

On behalf of my client Nihar Mohan P, a citizen of USA, I am issuing the following public notice. Be it known that my client Nihar Mohan P is the absolute owner of the land and building constructed in the year 1986 at Poes Garden, Tenampet, Mylapore, Chennai, Tamilnadu. The said property is an ancestral property of my client with house Nos. 91/40/1, 2 and 3, RS number 1567 in the Poes Garden layout admeasuring 5,364 sqft. The three floor structure is of approximately 8,500 sqft. Town survey number of the said property is 1567/90, Mylapore.

I am the CPA holder and custodian of the above property since 2013 and all relevant papers in original are in my possession.

My client has come to know that some vested interests are going around claiming to be CPA holders and that the original documents were lost. This is purely being done out of malafide intention to cheat. My client hereby notifies that he will not be held liable for any thing that the victims face and that those documents including GKPs and any document purportedly given by me are all fabricated ones.

My client has come to know of one specific individual bearing the name of Doda Sandeep showing Aadhaar number 37376689393 claiming to be holder of GPA. He has also come to know of few other individuals attempting to register as holders of GPA. My client shall not be liable for any losses in any format by those registering or entering into any transaction involving the said property.

K. JITHENDRA BABU
Advocate High Court
Off: Plot No. 2A, Nirmala Residency,
Bharathi Nagar Colony, Veperur,
NTR Dist. Andhra Pradesh - 520007.
Ph. 9488882600

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that my client intends to purchase the agricultural property described below from the owner named herein.

Property Details :

-Survey No.: 310/5, 312/2A, 312/2B, 312/3A
-Village: Kariyamangalam
-Taluk: Chengam
-District: Tiruvannamalai,
Tamil Nadu

Vendor:

Mr. M.R. Rajkumar Reddy
Any person, bank, financial institution, legal heir, or any other person claiming any right, title, interest, share, lien, charge, mortgage, lease, encumbrance, court attachment, or any other claim whatsoever over the above property is requested to notify the undersigned in writing, along with documentary proof, within 7 days from the date of publication of this notice.

If no objection or claim is received within the stipulated period, it will be presumed that no such claim exists, and my client will proceed with the purchase of the property. Any claim received thereafter shall not be binding on my client.

Date : 9-July-2026

Place : Tiruvannamalai

Sri.B.Sivakumar, M.A.B.L.,

Advocate& Notary

Rajamani Nivas, 1st Floor No.9,
Binny Compound Main Street
(Kumaran Road), Park Road,
Tirupur- 641601

Email: bskptr@gmail.com

cc to: bskoffice26@gmail.com

Mobile : 94430 38259,

WhatsApp : 90800 01000

**TICEL BIO PARK LTD**
(TIDCO Centre for Life Science)
CIN: U45309TN2001PLC047979
No.5, CSIR Road, Taramani, Chennai - 600 113.
Ph. +91 44 2254 2060, Email: md@ticebiopark.com

Date: 09.07.2026

TICEL invites e-Tender for the following works at TICEL Bio Park - I & II, Chennai.

Sl. No.	e-Tender No.	Name of the Tender	Tender Closing Date & Time
1.	e-TENDER No. TICEL/HK/2026-27/05	E-TENDER for "Providing Housekeeping, Plumbing and Garden Maintenance" for TICEL Bio Park Phase - I & II, CSIR Road, Taramani, Chennai-600 113.	10.08.2026 before 11.00 A.M.

For more details and participation in the above e-tender, please visit the website <https://www.tntenders.gov.in/>. Last date for online submission of duly filled tender documents is 10.08.2026 on or before 11.00 am. TICEL Bio Park Ltd reserves the right to accept/reject any one/all tenders without assigning any reason.

DIPR/2247/Tender/2026

Managing Director

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TENDERS

**Maharashtra Transmission Communication Infrastructure Ltd (MTCIL)**
113, 12th Floor, Building B,247 Park HCC Bus Stop, LBS Road, Gandhi Nagar Vikhrol west, Mumbai, Maharashtra 400079
Email : chirag.makwana@sterile.com, Contact : +91 9922002328 (CIN : U64201MH2012PLC234316)

TENDER NOTICE

MTCIL is a Joint Venture Company between Sterile Electric Ltd. (SEL) & Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Company Limited (MSETCL). It has been formed with the objective of establishing OPGW cable-based Communication Network in Maharashtra on existing EHV transmission lines of MSETCL and will exploit the same commercially as a Telecom Infrastructure Provider. Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Company Limited (MTCIL) is inviting requests for proposals from interested bidders for Supply of 96F & 144F OPGW Cable for 132kV to 400kV Transmission. Interested bidders may obtain the bid documents in person/ by courier/ post by sending request letter at above mentioned address and a Bid document fee of Rs 10,000/- through DD/online Mode in favor of 'Maharashtra Transmission Communication Infrastructure Ltd.' payable at Mumbai on or before 20th July 2026, 16.00 Hrs.

Scope of Work,	Qty. in Nos.	Date of Pre-bid Conference	Last date of seeking clarifications	Last date of Bid Submission
Supply of 96F&144F OPGW Cable includes (Planning, Design, Engineering, Utility drum schedule approval, Manufacturing, Supply, Handling, Inspection, testing at manufacturer's works, Type testing, Factory acceptance testing, Documentation of entire OPGW Packing, Handling, Loading, Transportation Insurance, Unloading, Delivery & demonstration for acceptance (after delivery of goods at stores).	514	24th July 2026 16.00 Hrs.	27th July 2026 18.00 Hrs.	30th July 2026 15.00 Hrs.

Mumbai 09th July 2026

SCM Head

**BENGALURU NORTH CITY CORPORATION**
Senior Assistant Director of Horticulture (Zone-1)
Bengaluru North City Corporation,
Amruthalli Main Road, Byatarayanapura, Bangalore -560092.

No: SADH(BNCC-Z1)TENDER/01/2026-27

Dated: 08.07.2026

INVITATION TENDER NOTIFICATION
(SHORT TERM) (TWO COVER SYSTEM)

The Senior Assistant Director of Horticulture (North Zone-01), BNCC, (Referred to as Employer in these documents) invites tenders to Implement in accordance with KTPP rules 2000, from eligible and experienced Person/Agencies / Firms (Referred to as Tenderers in these documents) registered in Labour department for Maintenance of Parks and Borewells.

(Standard Tender Document KW-1, KW-2, KW-3 & KW-4)

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Kushal Nagara ward parks (ward No 45). Estimate cost : Rs. 1,14,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 1,13,999.00, EMD: Rs. 1,425.00, Category : ST.
2.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Lingarajapura ward parks (ward No 29). Estimate cost : Rs. 1,19,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 1,19,000.00, EMD: Rs. 2,975.00, Category : Others.
3.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Doddanna Nagara ward parks (ward No 44). Estimate cost : Rs. 1,26,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 1,25,731.00, EMD: Rs. 3,150.00, Category : Others.
4.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Kammanahalli ward parks (ward No 35). Estimate cost : Rs. 3,28,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 3,27,730.00, EMD: Rs. 8,200.00, Category : Others.
5.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Subbaiahnapalya ward parks (ward No 34). Estimate cost : Rs. 3,46,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 3,45,995.00, EMD: Rs. 4,325.00, Category : SC.
6.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in HRBR Layout ward parks (ward No 33). Estimate cost : Rs. 3,60,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 3,59,800.00, EMD: Rs. 9,000.00, Category : Others.
7.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Venkateshapuram ward parks (ward No 28). Estimate cost : Rs. 3,87,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 3,86,960.00, EMD: Rs. 9,675.00, Category : Others.
8.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Rajiv Gandhi nagara ward parks (ward No 14). Estimate cost : Rs. 5,14,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 5,13,955.00, EMD: Rs. 12,850.00, Category : Others.
9.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Jeevanahalli ward parks (ward No 37). Estimate cost : Rs. 5,57,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 5,57,200.00, EMD: Rs. 13,925.00, Category : Others.
10.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in S.K Garden ward parks (ward No 48). Estimate cost : Rs. 5,62,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 5,61,990.00, EMD: Rs. 14,050.00, Category : Others.
11.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Shampura ward parks (ward No 38). Estimate cost : Rs. 7,09,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 7,08,520.00, EMD: Rs. 8,865.00, Category : SC.
12.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Maruthi Seva Nagara ward parks (ward No 36). Estimate cost : Rs. 8,39,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 8,37,930.00, EMD: Rs. 20,975.00, Category : Others.
13.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Sagayapuram ward parks (ward No 46). Estimate cost : Rs. 8,45,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 8,44,795.00, EMD: Rs. 10,565.00, Category : CAT-IIA.
14.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Hennuru ward parks (ward No 23). Estimate cost : Rs. 10,95,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 10,94,640.00, EMD: Rs. 13,690.00, Category : CAT-IIA.
15.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Kacharakannahalli ward parks (ward No 30). Estimate cost : Rs. 13,39,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 13,38,830.00, EMD: Rs. 33,480.00, Category : Others.

16.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Hebbala Kempapura ward parks (ward No 18). Estimate cost : Rs. 16,56,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 16,55,970.00, EMD: Rs. 41,400.00, Category : Others.
17.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Kaval Bairasandra ward parks (ward No 39). Estimate cost : Rs. 17,34,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 17,33,860.00, EMD: Rs. 43,350.00, Category : Others.
18.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Kalyana Nagara ward parks (ward No 31). Estimate cost : Rs. 18,96,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 18,96,000.00, EMD: Rs. 23,700.00, Category : CAT-IIA.
19.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in HBR Layout ward parks (ward No 24). Estimate cost : Rs. 19,83,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 19,82,999.00, EMD: Rs.49,600.00, Category : Others.
20.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Sampigehalli ward parks (ward No 20). Estimate cost : Rs. 21,50,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 21,49,750.00, EMD: Rs.25,000.00, Category : CAT-IIA.
21.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Kodigehalli ward parks (ward No 13). Estimate cost : Rs. 22,22,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 22,22,000.00, EMD: Rs.50,000.00, Category : Others.
22.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Thindlu ward parks (ward No 12). Estimate cost : Rs. 24,91,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 24,90,830.00, EMD: Rs.50,000.00, Category : Others.
23.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Vidyanarayapura ward parks (ward No 10). Estimate cost : Rs. 32,93,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 32,92,970.00, EMD: Rs.32,930.00, Category : ST
24.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Banasawadi ward parks (ward No 32). Estimate cost : Rs. 36,85,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 36,84,770.00, EMD: Rs.36,850.00, Category : ST
25.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Pulikeshinagara ward parks (ward No 47). Estimate cost : Rs. 37,30,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 37,30,000.00, EMD: Rs.37,300.00, Category : CAT-I
26.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Singapura ward parks (ward No 08). Estimate cost : Rs. 52,11,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 52,10,951.00, EMD: Rs.1,04,220.00, Category : Others.
27.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Byatarayanapura ward parks (ward No 15). Estimate cost : Rs. 54,60,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 54,58,670.00, EMD: Rs.1,09,200.00, Category : Others.
28.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Doddabommasandra ward parks (ward No 11). Estimate cost : Rs. 60,00,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 60,00,000.00, EMD: Rs.60,000.00, Category : CAT-IIA.
29.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Kogilu ward parks (ward No 21). Estimate cost : Rs. 66,00,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 65,96,540.00, EMD: Rs.66,000.00, Category : SC.
30.	Maintenance of Horticulture Works in Jakkuru ward parks (ward No 17). Estimate cost : Rs. 1,22,76,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs. 1,22,75,980.00, EMD:Rs.1,84,140.00, Category : Others.
31.	Maintenance & Repair works of Borewells at Sarvagna Nagara Constituency. Estimate cost : Rs. 25,00,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs.21,18,640.00, EMD: Rs.50,000.00, Category : Others.
32.	Maintenance & Repair works of Borewells at Pulikeshi Nagara Assembly Constituency Parks. Estimate cost : Rs. 20,00,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs.16,94,880.00, EMD: Rs.42,380.00, Category : Others.
33.	Maintenance & Repair works of Borewells at Byatarayanapura Assembly Constituency Parks. Estimate cost : Rs. 65,00,000.00, Amount put to Tender : Rs.55,08,424.00, EMD: Rs.1,10,200.00, Category : Others.

Calendar of Events : (1) Date of Notification : 08.07.2026 (2) Tender can be downloaded from : 10.07.2026 (3) Pre bid Meeting : 13.07.2026 at 11.30 AM (4) Tender Closing Date : 22.07.2026 at 4.00 PM (5) Technical bid opening date : 23.07.2026 at 4.30 PM (6) Financially bid opening date : After Approval Technical Bid.

Sd/- Senior Assistant Director of Horticulture
(North Zone-1), BNCC

S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER

Tender Notice No.: SHM-C-QWS-DT-080726. Open tender is invited by Sr. CDO., Santragachi, S.E.Railway, Kharagpur Division acting through the President of India through e-tendering in www.ireps.gov.in website as per details mentioned below. Eligible tenderers are requested to apply for the same through online only in www.ireps.gov.in website as per details mentioned below. No offline tender will be accepted. Please read the tender document uploaded in the document section for details. **Name of the work :** Shalimar : Setting-up of Quick Coach watering system at Shalimar Railway station. **Tender Value:** ₹ 5,30,82,496.34 only. (including all charges). **EMD:** ₹ 10,61,700/- only. **Cost of Tender document:** ₹ 0/- (Zero). **Closing date of tender:** 31.07.2026 at 11.30 hrs. (PR-438)

CENTRAL RAILWAY

SIGNALING WORK

OPEN TENDER NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (S&T), 1st Floor, Parcel Office Building, above P.F.No.14 & 15, Central Railway, Mumbai CST 400 001, for and on behalf of the President of India invites tenders from the reputed contractors. **S.N.:- 1.**
Name of work:- Signaling work in connection with fencing work in DIWA-PANVEL - ROHA & CSMT -PNVL, TNA (excl.) - Vashi (incl.) Harbour line of Mumbai division **TENDER NOTICE NO. CR/BB/NT/Est/2026/69.**
Approximate Cost:- Rs. 3.29/- **CORE. EMD:-** Rs. 659800/- **Date of Opening:-** 03.08.2026. **Validity:-** 60 days. **Completion Period:-** 18 Months. This tender complies with Public Procurement Policy (Make in India) Order 2017, dated 15/06/2017 Complete details of tenders are available at Central Railway. Official website www.ireps.gov.in the complete tender documents can be downloaded from the website. The complete details of tenders are also available in the "Notice Board" of the Divisional Railway Manager (S&T)'s Office, Mumbai CST. 337
Unauthorized crossing of railway line is a punishable offense

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE FOR ENGINEERING WORKS

Sr. No. 1: Tender No.: SECR-HQ-Engg-BL-26-27-11.
Work: Supply, replacement & fixing of HSFGB Bolts at various Bridges, through/patch painting, greasing, replacement of cracked/corroded members & epoxy grouting under the jurisdiction of SSE/Bridge/Shahdol in Bilaspur Division. **Tender Value:** ₹ 1,13,99,978.29. **Earnest Money Deposit:** ₹ 2,28,000/-.

Sr. No. 2: Tender No.: SECR-HQ-Engg-BL-26-27-12.
Work: Annual maintenance work of scour monitoring system at Bridge no. 182 DN (9x45, 70 M OWG), 86 DN (9x30.50 USGS+2x12.20 M Arch) and 404 (18x30, 5 M PSC girder) in SEC. Railway/Bilaspur. **Tender Value:** ₹ 10,24,200.00. **Earnest Money Deposit:** ₹ 20,500/-.

Bidding Start Date: 09.07.2026.
Tender Closing Date & Time: 16.30 hours on 23.07.2026.

For further details for the above work, please contact office of the Dy. CE/Bridge/Bilaspur or website: www.ireps.gov.in

Dy. CE/Bridge/ Bilaspur.

CPR/10/PH/260

f South East Central Railway % @secral

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE FOR ENGINEERING WORKS

Sr. No. (1) E-Tender No.: DRM-ENGG-BSP-T-134-26-27, Date: 03.07.2026.
Work: Cutting and widening of high banks in the approaches of major and minor Bridges, improvement of Cess, Trolley Refuge and other protection work under the jurisdiction of Assistant Divisional Engineer Umariya of Bilaspur Division. **Tender Value:** ₹ 5,13,31,095/- **Earnest Money Deposit:** ₹ 10,26,600/- **Completion Period:** 12 Months.

Sr. No. (2) E-Tender No.: DRM-ENGG-BSP-T-135-26-27, Date: 03.07.2026.
Work: Cutting and widening of high banks in the approaches of major and minor Bridges, improvement of Cess, Trolley Refuge and other protection work under the jurisdiction of Assistant Divisional Engineer Shahdol of Bilaspur Division. **Tender Value:** ₹ 5,73,92,583/- **Earnest Money Deposit:** ₹ 11,47,900/- **Completion Period:** 12 Months.

Sr. No. (3) E-Tender No.: DRM-ENGG-BSP-T-136-26-27, Date: 03.07.2026.
Work: Construction of Track Machine Stabling Sidings including P.Way Works, Pathways, Roads, RCC Tanks, Buildings, Dead Ends, Bridges Extension at Mauhari, Kotma, Udalkacher, Ambikapur, Bishrampur, Sursajpur Road & Darritola Railway Stations and Other miscellaneous works under the jurisdiction of Assistant Divisional Engineer Manendagarh. **Tender Value:** ₹ 9,64,77,198/- **Earnest Money Deposit:** ₹ 19,29,600/- **Completion Period:** 12 Months.

Sr. No. (4) E-Tender No.: DRM-ENGG-BSP-T-137-26-27, Date: 03.07.2026.
Work: Construction of Long Haul Loop Lines by Extension of Existing Loop Lines and/or Construction of New Railway Lines, including Formation, Bridge Extension/Construction, Blanketing and Connectivity to the Main Line for Long Haul formation/ Goods Parring Operations, along with Provision of Pathways and Other Associated Civil & P.Way Works at Lohra, Rupaund, Amlai, Mauhari and Bijuri Stations, including Construction of Track Machine Siding at Amlai Station, under the Jurisdiction of Senior Divisional Engineer North of Bilaspur Division. **Tender Value:** ₹ 42,82,21,585/- **Earnest Money Deposit:** ₹ 85,64,400/- **Completion Period:** 18 Months.

Start Date of Submission of Tender: From 11.00 hours on 14.07.2026. Last Date of Submission of Tender: Upto 11.00 hours on 28.07.2026.

The complete information of above e-Tender Notices is available over websites: <https://www.ireps.gov.in> Bids other than e-bids shall not be accepted against above Tenders. **Divisional Railway Manager(Engg) CPR/10/PH/268 Bilaspur.**
f South East Central Railway % @secral

**Pune Metropolitan Region Development Authority, Pune**
New Administrative Building, Near Akurdi Railway Station, Akurdi, Pune - 411044 Email: ad.pmrda@gmail.com

E-Tender No. 07 Year 2026-27

An e-tender is being floated for the appointment of an agency for the year 2026-27 for the recruitment of necessary of purely contractual manpower through Outsourcing agency within the limits of the vacant posts in the approved staffing pattern at the office of Pune Metropolitan Region Development Authority, Pune. The details of the said tender are being made available on the website www.mahatenders.gov.in from 11.00 AM on 09/07/2026. The last date for acceptance of tender is 3.00 PM on 29/07/2026. Any changes in the tender will be published on the website www.mahatenders.gov.in.

Sd/-
(Rupali Awale-Dambe)
Joint Commissioner, Administration
Pune Metropolitan Region Development Authority, Pune.

J.No. 1615/2026
Date 08/07/2026

**BENGALURU WEST CITY CORPORATION**
Office of the Executive Engineer, Vijayanagar Division, West Zone-2, 1st Floor, Shashakara Bhavan, 3rd Main, Vijayanagar, Bengaluru-560040, Mobile: 9480688282 E-mail: vijayanagardivision@gmail.com

No:EE(VJN)/TEND/KPPP/07/2026-27

Date: 08.07.2026

INVITATION FOR TENDER (IFT) (TWO COVER SYSTEM)
(Tender Notification) (Through GOK KPPP Portal only)

The Executive Engineer, Vijayanagar Division, BWCC invites standard tender documents KW-4 on behalf of the Commissioner, BWCC, Bengaluru from eligible Tenderers registered in GBA or equivalent registration with PWD/CPWD or any state Governmental Organization for the execution of works detailed in the table below. The tenderers may submit tenders for works given in the table through KPPP portal of the Government of Karnataka (viz <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>)

Sl. No.	Name of the Work/Estimate Cost in Lakhs/Amount Put to tender Rs. in Lakhs/ Period of Completion/EMD amount in Rs.
1	Additional development and Revitalisation works of Vijayanagar Cultural Boulevard & Footpath Development Works in Ward 85- Adichunangiri, 84-Hosahalli, 83-Hampinagara and 91 Gaali anjaneya & Compound Works at KAVIKA Layout PHASE-3 (Package-VJN-01) Annexure-3 (Action Plan No. 78). Est Cost : Rs.1500.00 Lakhs , Amount Put to Tender : 1185.37 Lakhs , EMD : Rs.15,00,000.00/- (Rs.1.00 lakh through e-procurement portal & the balance Rs.14,00,000/- shall be in the form of Bank Guarantee / FD) . Period of Completion : 11 Months .
2	Remodeling of Storm Water Drain Works at Vijayanagar Assembly Constituency 1.Storm Water Drain Cum Steel Bridge, Bend Pipes & Chain Link Fencing at 40 feet Road, K.PAgrahara. 2. Guide Wall & Bed Improvement at KAVIKA Layout & Under Gaali Anjaneya Bridge 3. Shamanna Garden & Manjunathanagar Linking Bridge 4. Secondary Drain works at near in Venkateshwara School Manjunathanagar 5.Storm Water Drain Jacketting Work for V102 Beside Satellite Bus Stand.6. RCC Box drain at Mango tree park in RPC layout (Package-VJN-04) Annexure-7 (Action Plan No. 23). Est Cost : Rs.1000.00 Lakhs , Amount Put to Tender : 788.86 Lakhs , EMD : Rs. 11,83,300.00 (Rs.1.00 lakh through e-procurement portal & the balance Rs. 10,83,300/- shall be in the form of Bank Guarantee / FD) . Period of Completion : 11 Months .
3	New & Existing Parks Developmental Work in Vijayanagar Assembly Constituency (Package-VJN-05) Annexure-7 (Action Plan No. 28). Est Cost : Rs.1500.00 Lakhs , Amount Put to Tender : 1185.37 Lakhs , EMD : Rs.15,00,000.00/- (Rs.1.00 lakh through e-procurement portal & the balance Rs.14,00,000/- shall be in the form of Bank Guarantee / FD) . Period of Completion : 11 Months .
4	Additional works for Ambedkar Bhavana at Avalahalli Ward in Vijayanagar Assembly Constituency (Package-VJN-06) Annexure-7 (Action Plan No. 30). Est Cost : Rs.1000.00 Lakhs , Amount Put to Tender : 788.86 Lakhs , EMD : Rs. 11,83,300.00 (Rs.1.00 lakh through e-procurement portal & the balance Rs. 10,83,300/- shall be in the form of Bank Guarantee / FD) . Period of Completion : 11 Months .
5	Additional development works Deepanjalinagar Lake. Phase-2 & Drilling of borewell and installation of pump & motors in Vijayanagara Assembly Constituency & Additional Works for Amar Javara Park development Work, Improvement of Play area at Opp Sky Line Apartment & Ornamental Poles for Street Lights to WOC Road in Vijayanagar Assembly Constituency and Ground Development Work in Vijayanagar Assembly Constituency & Additional works for Multipurpose Building opp Hyper Village Bazar in Vijayanagar Assembly Constituency (Package-VJN-07) Annexure-7 (Action Plan No. 24,27, 29, 31, 33). Est Cost : Rs.1200.00 Lakhs , Amount Put to Tender : 947.40 Lakhs , EMD : Rs.14,21,100.00 (Rs.1.00 lakh through e-procurement portal & the balance Rs.13,21,100/- shall be in the form of Bank Guarantee / FD) . Period of Completion : 11 Months .
6	Beautification Work of 3 Underpasses & Pedestrian Subway at Vijayanagar Assembly Constituency and Renovation Work for Smt Pramila Bayi Auditorium at Vijayanagar Ward in Vijayanagar Assembly Constituency and Additional work for Rangamandira, Commercial Complex, Multipurpose Building at 3rd Main Road, Basaveshwara Layout & Kanana Bhavana in Vijayanagar Assembly Constituency (Package-VJN-08) Annexure-7 (Action Plan No. 25, 26, 32). Est Cost : Rs.1000.00 Lakhs , Amount Put to Tender : 799.62 Lakhs , EMD : Rs.11,99,430.00 (Rs.1.00 lakh through e-procurement portal & the balance Rs. 10,99,430/- shall be in the form of Bank Guarantee / FD) . Period of Completion : 11 Months .

Time Schedule/Calendar of events :
1. Tender documents may be downloaded from the e-procurement portal : **From 10-07-2026**. 2. Last date of submission queries : **16-07-2026 within 3:00 p.m.** 3. Pre-Bid Meeting : **On 16-07-2026 at 4:00 p.m.** 4. Last Date & Time for receipt of tender : **On 18-07-2026 upto 4:00 p.m.** 5. Date & Time for Opening of technical bid : **On 20-07-2026 at 11.00 a.m.** 6. Date & Time for Opening of Financial bid : **21-07-2026 after 16.00 hrs.** 7. Validity of Tender : **180 days**

Sd/- Executive Engineer, (Vijayanagar), Zone-2, BWCC

**THE HINDU GROUP**

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NEW ARRIVAL

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Setting the gold standard

For Australia, which has been used to consistent success, a run without a title for three years would have been a bitter pill to swallow; however, its T20 World Cup triumph during the transition phase makes it the team to beat



P.K. Ajith Kumar
LONDON

One of sport's great anomalies was resolved last Sunday. Australia's women's cricket team won a World Cup. After a gap of three years.

For a team that was so used to winning and that too when it had so many match-winners, not having an ICC trophy for that long in the cabinet must have been a bit frustrating. Players like Ashleigh Gardner had admitted as much, ahead of the T20 World Cup final against England at Lord's.

At the 2025 ODI World Cup, the Aussies were beaten in the semifinal by India, or by an innings of a lifetime by Jemimah Rodrigues to be more precise, at Navi Mumbai. A year earlier, they were knocked out of the T20 World Cup in the UAE, too; they were humbled by the South Africans, who duly went on to crumble in the final against New Zealand.

In fact, it was after defeating the Proteas, in their own backyard, that the Australians had last won a World Cup. That was the sixth T20 World Cup for them. And that was only the eighth edition of the tournament.

So the Australians have now won seven of the 10 World Cups that have been held in the T20 format. After missing out on the inaugural edition in 2009, in which they lost in the semifinals to England, they triumphed in 2010, 2012 and 2014, and finished runner-up in 2016 to the West Indies. Then they scored another hat-trick of titles, in 2018, 2020 and 2023.

Impressive record

Thus, in every edition, they reached at least the semifinals. You may struggle to find another team that has as good a record in a global event, in any sport.

For all their previous triumphs, this one in England would have tasted particularly sweet. Not just it came after that three-year gap, for this was a team in transition and there was a new captain, whose appointment had surprised a few.

But, Sophie Molineux silenced all her critics. And she had to conquer her own doubts and concerns as well. Injuries hadn't helped, and she had to be played purely as a batter, which wasn't exactly an ideal situation. She,

however, recovered in time for the World Cup, where her left-arm spin rarely failed to produce a wicket for Australia. She went wicket-less only once in the seven matches, and often it did not take her long to strike.

Molineux was indeed relieved that she could lift that World Cup for Australia. When she was asked if there was a personal satisfaction for her after people had doubts about even her own place in the team, she replied with a smile: "Yep."

She admitted it hadn't been easy. "When I took over, I was a bit messy at the start, to be fair," she explained. "Captaining a couple of games and getting injured; it was a shock, and I suppose there were a few doubts internally, a few doubts externally. But I think what maybe I have learned over my journey so far is that you just have to keep believing and I am incredibly lucky that people believed in me. I believe in this team and this group more than anything as well, so it is really satisfying."

Molineux recalled the difficult days. "When I did miss those games at the start of the summer, after just being announced captain, it probably made me feel it might not work out," she said. "But I am so incredibly lucky with the support I have had over the last, not only just the last six months, but it has been 10 years in this team for Australia. The group has just been incredible in terms of being open to anything and being flexible and we have grown and evolved in the last six months more than I have ever seen."

The guide

Guiding that group quietly has been the coach, Shelley Nitschke. She was part of the Australian team that was the first to win the T20 World Cup, in 2010.

She said Sunday was one of the greatest days for her as a coach. She had been in charge of the team since 2022. "It was super pleasing to come out here and play like we did on the biggest stage in the T20 World Cup," she said. "I couldn't be prouder of the players and how they have gone about it this whole tournament."

Indeed. It was a totally dominant show by Nitschke's girls in the tournament. In the group stage, they began their campaign by crushing South Africa by 65 runs and followed it up with a thumping nine-wicket win against Bangladesh by nine wickets, a massive 98-run victory over the Netherlands and an even bigger win against Pakistan by 113 runs. Then in the last match of Group of Death, they beat India by six wickets.



And that was a match Harmanpreet Kaur's women needed to win if they wanted to remain in the competition. Thanks to a brilliant 27-ball 56 by the captain, India, cheered on by the big partisan crowd at Lord's, set a target of 171, but masterly century partnership by Ellyse Perry and Gardner, two of the finest all-rounders in the history of the women's game, shut India out of the match.

The West Indies was brushed aside by eight wickets in the semifinal. And in the final, in a huge disappointment for the full house at Lord's, England was beaten comfortably by seven wickets. The host stood little chance after managing just 150 for four. Making England bat indeed proved a great decision by Australia. It was the seasoned campaigner Beth Mooney who orchestrated the chase. And that was after coming up with a superb show behind the stumps.

Pat for Mooney

The coach was full of praise for Mooney. "She was unbelievable. We all know how good a player she is, but to be able to do that on the biggest stage certainly takes something special," said Nitschke. "And I think not only that, but probably the way she took the game on early in the piece and really took it to them in the PowerPlay and put us in a winning position. It takes a lot of bravery to do that." Nitschke said the tournament was a satisfying one for her personally too, after the disappointments of the last two World Cups. "It is really pleasing," she said. "I think you learn pretty quickly, you don't take anything for granted. So you need to make sure you enjoy it while you can, because we certainly know that it is really hard to win."

She said the most satisfying thing was the way Australia played. "I think when we lost the semifinals in Dubai at the last T20 World Cup, we were pretty

disappointed with how we were playing," she said. "And I think just the style of cricket that we've played, and obviously got the results as well, has been really pleasing. Again, just seeing the girls take the game on the biggest stage, that is pretty brave to do."

The coach said Molineux had been amazing as a captain. "She has shown how we could play, the freedom that we have played with," she said.

"She came on that West Indies tour as a batter only, and we felt like that was a good opportunity for her to get some game time as captain, and be out there working with the bowlers and leading the team on and off the field. I feel like that was a really important part of her journey, and started to really gel the group there, and then it built nicely into this World Cup."

Nitschke has watched from close quarters how Australia over the years evolved into an all-time great side. Women like Meg Lanning, Alyssa Healy, Megan Schutt, Tahlia McGrath, Gardner, Perry and Mooney have all played their parts, and now younger players like Phoebe Litchfield, Georgia Voll, Annabel Sutherland and Lucy Hamilton have shown how easily they could settle into international cricket and continue the legacy. "I think we are very lucky (to have such players)," Nitschke said.

Not for granted

"We certainly don't take the competitions for granted. It is a tough competition, and we know from the last couple of World Cups, that you need to be on at the right time and in the big moments. We are pretty driven by that, and continuing to get better and continuing to drive the game. It is a tough environment, the women's cricket at the moment."

It is just that Australia is considerably tougher than all the others at the moment.

THE GIST

Coach Nitschke has watched from close quarters how Australia has evolved into an all-time great side

For all their previous triumphs, this one in England would have tasted particularly sweet for the Aussies. Not only because it came after a three-year gap but also because it was a team in transition and there was a new captain

Skipper Molineux silenced her critics, conquering her own doubts and concerns as well

Quantum computing age will only begin when we silence the noise

Among other things, quantum computers are expected to herald a new era in how we optimise complex logistical networks and model natural phenomena that overwhelm even our most powerful supercomputers; however, hardware limitations stand between promise and performance

Savantan Datta
BENGALURU

In a paper published in the *Journal of Statistical Physics* in 1980, the American physicist Paul Benioff described what is now called the quantum Turing machine: a model of a computer that operated according to the laws of quantum mechanics.

Quantum mechanics is the branch of physics that studies the behaviour of matter and light at atomic and subatomic scales. At these scales, the certainty associated with classical mechanics disappears. Instead of pinpointing a particle's properties, scientists can only make educated guesses.

This uncertainty may sound daunting. But Benioff – and other scientists like the British physicist David Deutsch, American physicist Richard Feynman, and American computer scientist Peter Shor – suggested ways to harness it for computation. Their work eventually became the foundation for one of the contemporary world's most ambitious technological pursuits, one for which the Government of India sanctioned over ₹6,000 crore in April 2023.

By 2031, the National Quantum Mission (NQM) – whose objectives include building “intermediate-scale quantum computers” – is expected to “make India one of the leading nations in the development of Quantum Technologies & Applications,” according to the Department of Science & Technology website.

Beyond hype

Beyond nationalistic pride, the possibilities of a quantum computer are tantalising. Among other things, quantum computers are expected to herald a new era in how we simulate molecules and their interactions, secure our digital lives, optimise complex logistical networks, and model natural phenomena that overwhelm even our most powerful supercomputers.

However, those in the thick of it warn against hype. “It is worth treating claims you hear in the field with scepticism,” Jason Freidenfelds, spokesperson for Google Quantum AI, the tech giant's quantum computing research division, said. “To date no one has experimentally demonstrated a commercially relevant problem that can be solved by today's quantum computers that could not be solved by a classical supercomputer.”

Indian Institute of Science physicist Arindam Ghosh, who chairs the Karnataka Government's Quantum Task Force, agreed. “At least at this point of time, there is no reason to believe that the classical computing that we know as of today is going to go away in any form,” he said. Dr. Ghosh also led the vision document for the NQM's Quantum Materials and Devices vertical.

At the heart of this gap between promise and performance is hardware.

Building a quantum computer

The processors of classical computers are made of billions of tiny devices called transistors. Made of silicon, these can amplify or block electrical signals. If a transistor allows current to pass through it, it is said to be in the ON state (represented by the number 1); conversely, if it blocks electrical signals from passing, it is said to be in the OFF state (represented by 0).

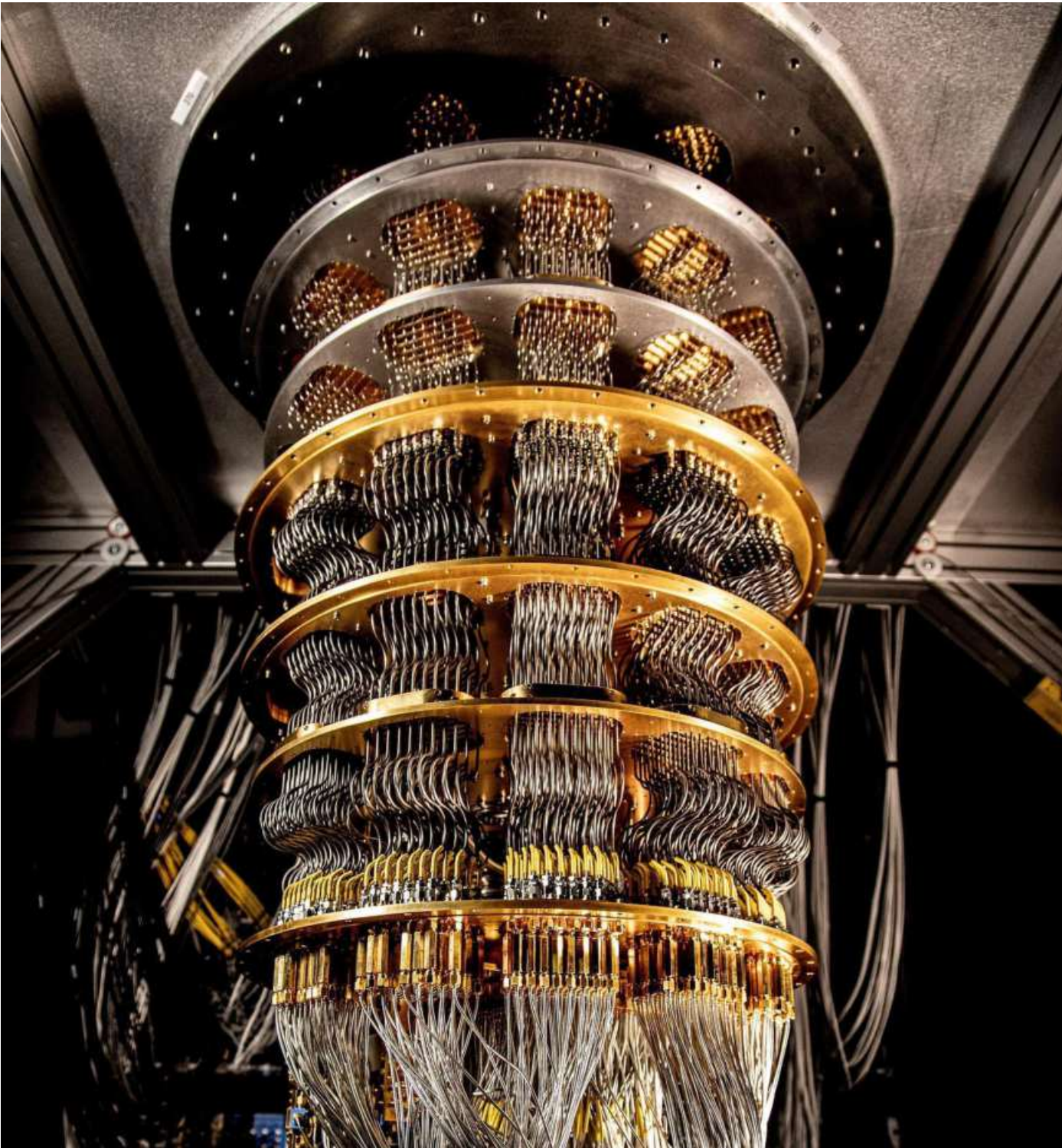
These states of a transistor form the fundamental unit of data in classical computers: a bit.

Quantum computers replace the bit with a qubit (‘quantum bit’). Unlike a bit, which can be either in the 0 or 1 states at any point of time, a qubit can exist in multiple states simultaneously: 0, 1, and any of the infinite states between them. This is like a coin tossed in the air; it is both heads and tails until it falls on the ground. This property is called superposition. It allows qubits to represent much larger amounts of information as compared with classical bits.

Further, thanks to the laws of quantum mechanics, qubits can also be entangled. That is, their states can become inextricably linked regardless of the physical distance between them. Any action or measurement made on one of the qubits will then affect the state of all other entangled qubits.

This makes quantum computers “massively parallel versions of a classical machine,” explained IIT-M quantum computing researcher Prabhu Rajagopal, the current Director-In-Charge of IIT-M's Zanzibar campus.

Superposition and entanglement massively increase the speed of processing – especially for tasks that



A cryostat refrigerator for cooling quantum computing chips is seen at the Google Quantum AI lab in California, U.S., on December 6, 2024. REUTERS

require a machine to work with large amounts of data and compare many different solutions of a problem. Examples of such tasks include “sorting algorithms and search algorithms,” Dr. Ghosh suggested.

Sorting algorithms provide instructions on how to rearrange a group of items into a specific order; for example, an online store that organises products by price in real-time. Search algorithms dictate how to find specific data points from a large set of data (for example, finding which two metals will form an alloy with required properties from all possible combinations of metals).

Depending on their origin, qubits can be of different types. Superconducting qubits are made from a device called the Josephson junction. It involves two superconductors – materials that allow current to flow through them with almost negligible resistance – separated by a thin barrier. Google's quantum processor Willow, launched in December 2024, is an example.

Other ways of fabricating qubits include using tiny particles of semiconductors like silicon, gallium arsenide, or germanium (called quantum dot qubits); trapping and manipulating individual ions (trapped ion qubits); manipulating particles of light (photonic qubits); and using the angular momentum of nuclei within molecules (nuclear magnetic resonance, or NMR, qubits).

Perfect machine, imperfect parts

In 1998, two groups of researchers – one from Oxford University, and another consisting of scientists from IBM, University of California Berkeley, Stanford University, and the Massachusetts Institute of Technology – unveiled for the first time a quantum computer consisting of two NMR qubits. On that computer, they solved the Deutsch-Jozsa problem, demonstrating for the first time that quantum computers can solve certain problems dramatically faster than classical computers.

The Deutsch-Jozsa problem asks a computer to determine whether a mathematical function is constant or balanced. Functions are rules that take an input and process it to produce a corresponding output. A constant function would return the same value for all possible inputs. A balanced function, on the other hand, would return different outputs for different inputs. Although the problem was of little practical use, the milestone was important. A quantum

computer had been realised.

Since then, tech companies have raced to create increasingly larger processors, with California-based Atom Computing having reported in 2023 a quantum computer with over 1,000 qubits. Today's quantum computers have outperformed classical computers on a benchmark, successfully ran algorithms that would take classical computers impractically long amounts of time, and have computed the structures of some small molecules.

Yet they are still years away from being practically useful, all researchers this reporter spoke to agreed. Part of the challenge is to make processors with more qubits. The other, more important part is to deal with “noise and errors,” Dr. Rajagopal, the IIT-M quantum computing researcher, pointed out. This is why California Institute of Technology quantum computing researcher John Preskill called contemporary quantum processors “Noisy Intermediate-Scale Quantum Computing”.

Qubits are incredibly sensitive and short-lived. Any interaction with the environment – including with particles of light – lead to qubits losing their quantum states, a phenomenon called decoherence. To prevent this, qubits are isolated from the environment and cooled to temperatures near absolute zero (-273 °C).

Further, the mechanisms by which qubits are controlled and manipulated, like lasers or microwave pulses, are themselves rarely perfect. Together, these lead to quantum processors being prone to noise, and, eventually, errors.

Contemporary quantum processors have error rates of 1% to 0.1%. That is, one out of every 100 to 1000 quantum operations results in an error. In contrast, classical computers make errors at the rate of one out of every quintillion (10 followed by 17 zeroes) operations. In fact, some researchers, like University of Copenhagen's Michael Kastoryano, have suggested that error rates of quantum processors are unlikely to decrease beyond one out of 1,00,00,000 operations.

Then the challenge facing quantum computing is, in the words of *Quanta Magazine*, “how do you construct a perfect machine out of imperfect parts?”

Fixing errors

The answer: error correction. This is a set of techniques that forces several qubits to work together as a single “logical qubit”.

A computer can then use several such logical qubits to perform calculations.

There is, however, one problem. Merely adding more qubits doesn't help. If each qubit is prone to errors, adding more qubits could worsen the performance of logical qubits. But if scientists can push the error rate for individual qubits below a certain threshold, we get a system whose error rate drops exponentially with each additional qubit.

That is exactly what Google Quantum AI researchers showed for the first time in a 2024 *Nature* paper with their processor Willow. “Each time we increase our encoded qubits from a 3x3 to a 5x5 to a 7x7 lattice of physical qubits, the encoded error rate is suppressed by a factor of two,” team members Michael Newman and Kevin Satzinger wrote in a 2024 blog post explaining the study. “This culminates in a logical qubit whose lifetime is more than twice of its best constituent physical qubit,” they added.

With that, Google is working on its next target: “a long-lived logical, or error-corrected, qubit,” spokesperson Freidenfelds said. “We expect the first useful quantum computing applications within the next five years.”

Ultimately, Google plans to tile thousands of these logical qubits together to create a “fully fault-tolerant quantum computer,” he added. IBM expects to debut theirs by 2029.

‘Everything will change’

If these projections are correct, a practically useful quantum computer is practically knocking at our doors. The anticipation among scientists is palpable. “Everything would change” is their common refrain.

“The day we get an industrial-grade quantum computer, everything in this field of climate modelling [will] change,” Manmeet Singh, climate modeller and assistant professor at the Western Kentucky University, said. Dr. Ghosh and Dr. Rajagopal echoed his excitement, albeit about the role of quantum computers in materials modelling and cryptography.

While it may take some time for quantum computers to make their way to laptops, if at all, “it could cause a technological revolution well before that,” Dr. Ghosh said.

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The WHO has so far marked 506 deaths and 1,561 confirmed Ebola cases in the DRC. REUTERS

Countries try again to seal pandemic treaty after Ebola jolt

Agence France-Presse
GENEVA

World Health Organisation (WHO) member states kicked off another attempt at finalising the missing piece of the pandemic treaty here on Monday, with the Ebola outbreak in Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) injecting a fresh sense of urgency.

Wealthy countries and developing nations are at loggerheads in talks at the WHO's headquarters over how the pandemic agreement, adopted last year, will work in practice.

Though the treaty was agreed in May 2025, how its key mechanism would operate was left out to get the deal over the line.

The accord aims at preventing a repeat of the disjointed international response that surrounded COVID-19, by improving global coordination and timely access to vaccines

The agreement's Pathogen Access and Benefit-Sharing (PABS) system deals with sharing access to pathogens with pandemic potential, then sharing benefits derived from them such as vaccines, tests, and treatments.

It was meant to be finalised by May 2026, but progress has been agonisingly slow.

Negotiations have often gone late into the night, producing slender advances and leaving diplomats drained. This two-week session until July 17 is the seventh such round of talks.

As the number of confirmed Ebola deaths in the DRC outbreak topped 500, WHO chief Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus urged countries to grasp the nettle.

“Keep the destination in sight,” pleaded the UN health agency's Director-General.

“A future in which pathogen samples and information move quickly, without needless delay; and in which the benefits that come from them reach the people who need them most, fairly and in time.”

The Ebola outbreak in the DRC, declared in mid-May, is a “painful” reminder that “the threat never truly goes away”, Mr. Ghebreyesus said.

There have been 1,561 confirmed cases in the DRC, including 506 confirmed deaths, and the outbreak has spilled over into neighbouring Uganda.

“Danger can emerge from anywhere, at any time, in ways we don't always expect,” he added.

Before last month's G7 summit, the WHO chief and Brazilian President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva urged its leaders to find the “political will” themselves ensure the PABS annex gets finished, and “treat July 17 as a deadline, not a milestone”.

The pandemic agreement was struck after more than three years of negotiations sparked by the shock of COVID-19.

The accord aims at preventing a repeat of the disjointed international response that surrounded the coronavirus crisis, by improving global coordination, surveillance and access to vaccines.

The Third World Network, an NGO that is monitoring the negotiations, has insisted that meaningful progress “requires developed countries coming down from their maximalist positions and adopting a positive and a constructive outlook”.

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Share of declared foreigners repatriated in Assam since 2021

0.5 in per cent. Over 36,000 people have been declared foreigners since 2021, but only 196 have been deported to Bangladesh, the Assembly was informed. Under the Assam Accord, foreigners who entered Assam on or after March 25, 1971, are to be identified and deported. PTI

Number of farmer suicides recorded in Marathwada region

465 The Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar district reported the highest number of cases at 109, an official report said on Wednesday. According to the report, 215 suicide cases were found eligible for financial aid from the government. PTI

Children killed or injured in Sudan war in six months

300 The Sudanese military and the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces have been fighting since April 2023. The war is now concentrated in the Kordofan, Darfur and Blue Nile states, with drone warfare causing 60% of casualties, according to UNICEF. PTI

Karnataka: share of SIR enumeration forms distributed

80 in per cent. Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer V. Anbukkumar said that 80.85% of the enumeration forms had been distributed to electors across the State. He said Bommanahalli had recorded 35% distribution, the lowest in Karnataka. PTI

Number of people killed in Balochistan over past four days

92 At least 54 terrorists, 38 security personnel and four civilians were killed during the last four days in various incidents in the restive Balochistan province, the ISPR said on Wednesday. The trouble began on the night of July 4 and 5. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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What is the right to be forgotten?

How does the ruling balance privacy with open justice and free speech? What challenges remain in enforcing the right to be forgotten? What role does the DPDP Act play? Who should decide requests for erasure or de-indexing?

EXPLAINER

G.S. Bajpai

The story so far:

The Delhi High Court, in its recent ruling, has laid down the principles governing the right to be forgotten. The court has evolved a new jurisprudence to protect the privacy of those who continue to be victimised on account of their digital footprints on social media and elsewhere, despite having those matters settled in their favour.

What is the ‘right to be forgotten’?

The “right to be forgotten” is the right to have information erased or de-indexed from the public digital environment when its continued accessibility is harmful and serves no public interest.

The concept came to the fore in 2014, when a Spanish citizen, Mario Costeja González, complained to the European Court of Justice that Google continued to display an old newspaper notice about the auction of his repossessed house even though the debt had been settled. The court ruled in his favour, laying the groundwork for the right to erasure, which was later incorporated into Article 17 of the European Union’s General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR).

How has the idea of the right to be forgotten evolved in Indian law?

The Supreme Court’s judgment in *K.S. Puttaswamy v. Union of India* (2017) held that privacy is a fundamental right under Article 21, including the right to informational privacy. In the years that followed, however, High Courts adopted divergent approaches.

While some permitted anonymisation in limited cases, such as the Delhi High Court ordering the masking of names in certain matrimonial and criminal matters, others rejected similar requests on



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grounds of open justice.

The real challenge was the lack of a coherent framework to balance these competing interests, which the May 2026 Delhi High Court judgment sought to address.

What did the Delhi High Court decide?

On May 29, the Delhi High Court ruled in a batch of over 30 consolidated petitions, led by *Laksh Vir Singh Yadav v. Union of India*. The core issue was whether informational privacy could justify the de-indexing or masking of judicial records in a system committed to open justice. The court held that the right to be forgotten flows from Article 21’s guarantee of dignity and informational privacy. The structured proportionality test is that retention must have a legitimate purpose, that the harm to privacy must be balanced against the public interest, and that the least intrusive means, typically by masking names instead of deleting the entire judgment, should be preferred. The court also prescribed a two-week

deadline for legal databases to comply and explained that only the parties’ names should be redacted, not the facts of the case.

How does the right to be forgotten interact with constitutional values?

This is not a stand-alone right. It frequently conflicts with freedom of speech and press under Article 19(1)(a), the principle of open justice, and the public’s right to know. A right to privacy must be sacrificed when the public interest is of a high order, particularly in serious cases of crime, but the digital presence should not destroy a person’s life long after the trial ends. The judgments are still publicly accessible by case number or a keyword search; only name-based searches are restricted.

What are the practical challenges?

The toughest aspect is enforcement. An acquittal judgment may still appear highly in name-based searches even after a court has ordered the removal of the search results. Search engines are designed so

that the original accusation, or the “shadow of crime,” is often the first thing the user sees. De-indexing can benefit at the search level, but it won’t prevent mirrors, archive copies, or social media sharing. Without effective technical compliance and coordination among platforms, the right may remain largely symbolic.

What is the relationship between the right to be forgotten and DPDP Act?

As of now, the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, offers a limited statutory right to erasure in section 12. It is primarily based on consent and does not explicitly address judicial records and public archives, where the right to be forgotten is most needed. The Act is deficient because rules have not been notified and the data protection board has not been completely effective.

Who should decide requests for erasure or de-indexing?

The challenge lies in balancing efficiency with accountability. Requiring every request to be decided by a court would create significant bottlenecks, while leaving such decisions entirely to technology companies raises concerns about due process and transparency. A more sensible approach would be a tiered system, where cases could be heard by platforms, contested ones by the data protection board, and judicial cases by courts.

The Delhi High Court has established an important framework, but until the Supreme Court rules on the matter, establishes a data protection board, and platforms comply with it, this ruling will be mostly declaratory. The conflict over freedom of expression and open justice is a reality. The task ahead is now to establish the institutions that facilitate it. (G. S. Bajpai is Vice Chancellor at National Law University Delhi. He acknowledges the assistance of Vibhuti Sharma, Academic fellow, NLU Delhi. Views are personal)

THE GIST

▼ The Delhi High Court has recognised the right to be forgotten as part of the fundamental right to privacy under Article 21, laying down a framework that balances informational privacy with open justice and freedom of speech by favouring name-masking over deletion of judgments.

▼ While the ruling provides a legal framework for de-indexing and erasure requests, its effectiveness depends on enforcement by platforms, the operationalisation of the DPDP Act, and the establishment of institutions such as the data protection board.

What is the ‘Hummus trail’ and why is it under scrutiny?

Can India arrest foreign nationals accused of grave breaches under the Geneva Conventions?

Nivedita S.

The story so far:

In June 2, 2026, the Hind Rajab Foundation (HRF), a Palestinian rights organisation based in Brussels, filed a complaint with the Union Ministry of Home Affairs, the Bureau of Immigration and the police to arrest Eitan Gilboa, an Israeli soldier, who was found to be vacationing in Himachal Pradesh. Gilboa, a member of the 271st Combat Engineering Battalion, was accused by the organisation of committing “war crimes in Gaza” in 2024. The organisation submitted evidence that involves specific instances in which he participated in the destruction of residential buildings and civilian infrastructure in Khan Yunis and Rafah. He filmed videos of himself celebrating the execution of these activities, which were later posted on social media by his mother. The HRF provided geo-located videos, social media videos and chain-of-command documentation along with the complaint.

How does Indian law apply to alleged war crimes?

The HRF alleged that these activities by Gilboa were in violation of the Fourth Geneva Convention, to which India is a signatory. Under this convention, any intentional launch of an attack which is known to cause loss of life or injury to civilians, along with severe damage to civilian objects, is considered to be a war crime and a grave breach of the convention.

Though India does not have its own law criminalising war crimes, it has passed the Geneva Conventions Act, 1960. Under this law, any act which constitutes a ‘grave breach’ under four sections of the Geneva Convention is criminalised. India can arrest any person, irrespective of nationality, if found to have committed an offence under the convention, regardless of the geographical location of the offence.

If an arrest is not possible, the Home Ministry and the Bureau of Immigration can facilitate the deportation of the accused from Indian territory. However,

the Union government did not issue a statement regarding the allegations by HRF, nor initiated a probe.

What is the ‘Hummus trail’?

Though Gilboa has now fled India, he was traced by pro-Palestinian activists and the HRF in Old Manali and Gondla Village of Himachal Pradesh, which are popular spots among Israelis along the ‘Hummus trail’.

Every year, around 80,000 Israelis visit India, a large number of them young veterans who have been discharged from the mandatory Israeli army service. This trip, known as the Tiul Gadol, could last up to 6 months or a year and is mainly funded by the bonus they receive after serving in the army. In February 2026, the Israeli government allocated four million NIS to boost tourism collaboration with India.

From the north to the south of the country, there are several areas which are frequented by Israelis, and this is colloquially known as the ‘Hummus trail in India’. This includes Kasol (also known

as mini-Israel), Kodaikanal, Kerala, Goa, Hampi, Gokarna, Rishikesh, Varanasi, Pushkar, Almora, Dharamkot, and, more recently, the Andaman and Nicobar Islands.

In these places frequented by Israelis, one can observe several changes to the cultural landscape. It is common to see signs in Hebrew, posters promoting the Israeli Defence Forces, along with cafes, stores and hostels run by Israelis. In 2015, an Israeli-run cafe in Himachal Pradesh faced backlash for allegedly denying entry to Indians with a ‘whites only’ sign.

According to a 2020 study published in the Journal of Travel & Tourism Marketing, drug abuse and rave parties are common along the Hummus trail, with drug peddling cases on the rise in these regions.

The study found that to cope with mental health challenges faced by these veterans during their service in the army, they resort to high drug consumption. Mental health workers from Israel have also been sent to India to aid these reservists.

Why is the issue drawing global attention?

“India-Israel tourism is not merely about routine holidays and cultural exchange. It is part of a broader normalisation process that seeks to deepen social and economic ties between the two countries,” Azad Essa, author of *Hostile Homelands: The New Alliance Between India and Israel*, told *The Hindu*. He added that Israel has thanked India multiple times for being

one of the few countries that have provided political and moral support to Israel, when much of the world has turned its back on it, at least publicly.

As Israel has killed over 73,000 Palestinians in the Gaza Strip since the October 7, 2023, Hamas attack, and is currently facing a case filed by South Africa in the International Court of Justice over allegations of genocide, allowing unrestricted entry of Israeli soldiers to India after their service in Gaza demands scrutiny.

The UN Commission of Inquiry, in its report, has said that the Israeli military “deliberately carried out acts inflicting death and severe bodily and mental harm on hundreds of thousands of Palestinian children.”

Five-year-old Hind Rajab is among the thousands of children killed by the Israeli forces in Gaza.

The HRF’s legal action in other countries against Israeli soldiers travelling there has resulted in successful outcomes in Brazil, Romania, Peru, Belgium, and Canada, according to its website. A court in Chile is the latest to recognise universal jurisdiction over war crimes in Gaza while hearing HRF’s complaint against Rom Kovtn, an Israeli-Ukrainian citizen accused of war crimes during the siege of Al-Shifa Hospital in Gaza.

“The ‘Hummus Trail’ – or these extended trips that IDF soldiers take to decompress after military duties – cannot become a route for impunity,” Natacha Bracc, Head of Litigation at the HRF, said in a statement.

